Catechism.

YEAR 1 · UNIT 11 · DAYS 334-378

The Divided Kingdom and Early Prophets

1 Kings 12-2 Kings 17, Amos, Hosea, Jonah, Micah

The covenant fractures. God sends prophets to call his people back.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"For I desire steadfast love and not sacrifice, the knowledge of God rather than burnt offerings."

HOSEA 6:6

Laments and cries for justice (42 to 44, 58, 82, 94, 109, 74, 77) beside the prophets' protests.

UNIT 11

In this unit

WEEK 48

334	1 Kings 12:1-14:20	*Reading*
335	1 Kings 14:21-16:34	*Reading*
336	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 49

337	Psalm 42	*Psalm*
338	Psalm 43	*Psalm*
339	1 Kings 17:1-19:21	*Reading*
340	1 Kings 20:1-22:53	*Reading*
341	2 Kings 1:1-2:25	*Reading*
342	2 Kings 3:1-4:44	*Reading*
343	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 50

344	Psalm 44	*Psalm*
345	Psalm 60	*Psalm*
346	2 Kings 5:1-6:33	*Reading*
347	2 Kings 7:1-8:29	*Reading*
348	2 Kings 9:1-10:36	*Reading*
349	2 Kings 11:1-13:25	*Reading*
350	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 51

351	Psalm 50	*Psalm*
352	Psalm 52; Psalm 53	*Psalm*
353	2 Kings 14:1-15:38	*Reading*
354	Amos 1:1-2:16	*Reading*
355	Amos 3:1-5:27	*Reading*

356	Amos 6:1-9:15	*Reading*
357	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 52

358	Psalm 58	*Psalm*
359	Psalm 82	*Psalm*
360	Psalm 94	*Psalm*
361	Psalm 109	*Psalm*
362	Psalm 140; Psalm 142	*Psalm*
363	Hosea 1:1-3:5	*Reading*
364	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 53

365	Hosea 4:1-7:16	*Reading*
366	Hosea 8:1-11:12	*Reading*
367	Hosea 12:1-14:9	*Reading*
368	Psalm 74	*Psalm*
369	Psalm 77	*Psalm*
370	Jonah 1:1-2:10	*Reading*
371	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 54

372	Jonah 3:1-4:11	*Reading*
373	Micah 1:1-3:12	*Reading*
374	Micah 4:1-5:15	*Reading*
375	Micah 6:1-7:20	*Reading*
376	2 Kings 16:1-17:41	*Reading*
377	Review and Reflection	*Review*
378	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

DAY 334 · WEEK 48

1 Kings 12:1-14:20

The kingdom divides; Jeroboam's golden calves

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 62 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Kings 12:1-14:20. The kingdom splits in two, and Jeroboam makes a fateful religious decision. Read the account of Rehoboam's choice and Jeroboam's golden calves carefully, because this sin will be named again and again through the rest of Kings.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Solomon is dead, and his son Rehoboam goes to Shechem to be confirmed as king. The northern tribes ask for relief from the heavy labor and taxes Solomon imposed. What Rehoboam decides will tear the kingdom apart, as God had said through the prophet Ahijah. Around 930 BC, the nation splits into the northern kingdom of Israel under Jeroboam and the southern kingdom of Judah under Rehoboam. This begins the story of the divided kingdom.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The people say, "Your father made our yoke heavy. Now therefore lighten the hard service of your father" (12:4).
2. Rehoboam rejects the counsel of the old men who served Solomon and follows the young men (12:6-14).
3. "My father made your yoke heavy, but I will add to your yoke. My father disciplined you with whips, but I will discipline you with scorpions" (12:14).
4. "What portion do we have in David? We have no inheritance in the son of Jesse. To your tents, O Israel!" (12:16).
5. "So Israel has been in rebellion against the house of David to this day" (12:19).

6. Jeroboam says in his heart, “If this people go up to offer sacrifices in the temple of the LORD at Jerusalem, then the heart of this people will turn again to their lord” (12:26-27).
7. He makes two golden calves and says, “Behold your gods, O Israel, who brought you up out of the land of Egypt” (12:28).
8. “And this thing became a sin” (12:30).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The narrator is clear that the split was God’s doing: “It was a turn of affairs brought about by the LORD.” It was judgment on Solomon’s idolatry. But that does not excuse Rehoboam. He had the chance to serve. The old men told him, “If you will be a servant to this people today and serve them… they will be your servants forever.” It was wise advice, and it is the way of a true king. But Rehoboam chose arrogance over service, the way of Pharaoh rather than of a shepherd. A proud word split a nation.

Jeroboam received a promise. Through Ahijah, God had said that if he walked in God’s ways, he would have “an enduring house, as I built for David.” It was a remarkable offer. But Jeroboam did not trust it. He feared that if the people went to Jerusalem to worship, they would go back to Rehoboam. So he set up his own religion for political reasons: two golden calves at Bethel and Dan, his own priests, and his own festival. “He had devised from his own heart.” It was convenient, efficient, and idolatrous.

This is the “sin of Jeroboam,” and it becomes the measuring stick for every northern king after him. Notice what he did. He took the story of the exodus, “who brought you up out of the land of Egypt,” and attached it to a calf. He did not reject the LORD. He reshaped worship to suit his needs. It is a warning about religion that is designed for convenience or politics. When we decide how God should be worshiped, we are no longer following him.

Chapter 13 shows the seriousness. A man of God from Judah prophesies against the altar, but he is deceived by an old prophet and killed by a lion. The message is that obedience to God’s word must be complete. And chapter 14 ends with the death of Jeroboam’s son and the prophecy that God will “give Israel up because of the sins of Jeroboam, which he sinned and made Israel to sin.”

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the king who came not to be served but to serve (Mark 10:45), where Rehoboam threatened scorpions. He is the true shepherd, who united what was divided: “He himself is our peace, who has made us both one” (Ephesians 2:14). Jesus said that true worshipers “will

worship the Father in spirit and in truth" (John 4:23-24), not in a religion of our own devising. Paul warns of a religion of "self-made" worship (Colossians 2:23).

STEP 6

Application

Ask where you are tempted to answer pressure with pride instead of service.

Consider whether you have shaped your faith around convenience rather than God's word.

Pray for the unity of Christ's church, divided in many ways.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to keep you from Rehoboam's pride and Jeroboam's convenient religion.
- Ask him to teach you to serve and not to rule harshly.
- Ask him to help you worship him as he has revealed.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 48

"Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and do not lean on your own understanding. In all your ways acknowledge him, and he will make straight your paths."

PROVERBS 3:5-6

DAY 335 · WEEK 48

1 Kings 14:21-16:34

A succession of unfaithful kings; Ahab and Jezebel

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 73 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Kings 14:21-16:34. The narrative moves quickly through a series of kings in Judah and Israel. Notice the repeated formulas, and slow down at the arrival of Ahab and Jezebel.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

In the decades after the split, the books of Kings tell the story of both kingdoms side by side. The author uses a formula for each king: when he began to reign, how long he reigned, and a verdict on whether he did right or evil in the eyes of the LORD. In the south, Rehoboam, Abijam, and Asa reign. In the north, a succession of kings, with coups and civil war, leads to Omri and then to his son Ahab.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Judah under Rehoboam did evil: they built high places, pillars, and Asherim, and there were male cult prostitutes in the land (14:22-24).
2. Shishak king of Egypt attacks Jerusalem and takes the treasures of the temple (14:25-26).
3. “For David’s sake the LORD his God gave him a lamp in Jerusalem” (15:4).
4. “Asa did what was right in the eyes of the LORD, as David his father had done” (15:11).
5. Asa removes idols and his own mother’s position as queen mother, but “the high places were not taken away” (15:12-14).
6. Northern kings rise and fall: Nadab, Baasha, Elah, Zimri, Omri, each “walking in the way of Jeroboam” (15:25-16:28).

7. “Ahab the son of Omri did evil in the sight of the LORD, more than all who were before him” (16:30).
8. He married Jezebel, daughter of the king of Sidon, “and went and served Baal and worshiped him” (16:31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The summaries can seem repetitive, but the repetition teaches. In the north, king after king “walked in the way of Jeroboam.” No dynasty lasts. Baasha kills Nadab. Zimri kills Elah and reigns seven days before burning his own palace. Omri comes to power. The northern kingdom is unstable because it is built on a false foundation. Without the Davidic promise, it has no secure line.

In the south, the pattern is different. Even when kings are bad, there is a recurring phrase: “for David’s sake the LORD gave him a lamp in Jerusalem.” God’s faithfulness to the covenant with David continues. A lamp is a small light, but it does not go out. Judah’s survival, in spite of its unfaithful kings, is a sign of grace.

Asa stands out as a reformer. He removes idols and even deposes his grandmother for making an image of Asherah. It is a costly act of obedience. But his reform is incomplete, because the high places remain. And later, when threatened by Baasha, Asa will turn to a foreign king rather than to the LORD (2 Chronicles 16). Even the best kings have limits.

Chapter 16 introduces the worst. Ahab is described as doing evil “more than all who were before him.” The narrator says it was a “light thing” for him to walk in the sins of Jeroboam. He went further and married Jezebel, a Sidonian princess devoted to Baal, and built a temple and altar for Baal in Samaria. The northern kingdom is now officially committed to a foreign god of storms and fertility.

The chapter ends with a detail that reaches back to Joshua. Hiel of Bethel rebuilds Jericho “at the cost of Abiram his firstborn,” fulfilling Joshua’s curse. God’s word does not fail. The same word that brought the walls down still stands.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the Davidic king whose light is not a small lamp but the light of the world (John 8:12). Where the kings of Israel and Judah failed one after another, he is the one faithful king. Matthew 6:24 states that no one can serve two masters, a truth Ahab’s reign illustrated. 1 John 5:21 says, “Little children, keep yourselves from idols.”

STEP 6

Application

Ask what “high places” remain in your life, areas you have not fully surrendered.

Thank God for the lamp he keeps burning for his promises.

Consider how easily “light things” become heavy. What small compromise do you tolerate?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for keeping a lamp burning for the sake of his promise.
- Ask him to keep you from half-obedience and the high places you leave standing.
- Ask him to help you serve him alone.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 48

“Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and do not lean on your own understanding. In all your ways acknowledge him, and he will make straight your paths.”

PROVERBS 3:5-6

DAY 336 · WEEK 48

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Proverbs 3:5-6 once more, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and do not lean on your own understanding. In all your ways acknowledge him, and he will make straight your paths."

PROVERBS 3:5-6

REST

Meditation

You memorized this verse in the last unit. Today, return to it with the opening of the divided kingdom in mind.

Rehoboam leaned on his own understanding. He took the counsel of his young friends and refused the advice of the elders. The result was a torn nation. Jeroboam leaned on his own understanding too. He feared losing his people and invented a new religion. The result was a sin that haunted a kingdom for two hundred years. Both are living illustrations of what happens when we do not trust the LORD with all our heart.

The verse does not say that thinking is bad. It says that our own understanding is not the final guide. We are limited. We cannot see the future. We cannot see the heart of another. We cannot be sure of our own motives. When we rest our whole weight on what seems wise to us, we are in danger.

“In all your ways acknowledge him.” Rehoboam did not consult God. He did not ask. Jeroboam did not ask either. He worked out a plan that made sense politically. But acknowledging the LORD means bringing him into the decision, before we act. It means asking, “What has God said?”

“And he will make straight your paths.” Note that this is a promise for those who trust. God will direct the paths. This is a comfort for anyone who has made a mess of things. It is not too late to begin trusting.

Hold this verse as the unit moves into a darker period. In a time of idolatry and violence, the way to stay faithful is not to rely on our own cleverness but on the LORD.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week the united kingdom of David and Solomon came apart. You read of Rehoboam’s proud answer and Jeroboam’s golden calves, and the sin of Jeroboam that became the standard of evil for the northern kings. You saw how God kept a lamp for David’s sake in Jerusalem, even as Judah’s kings failed. You followed the quick succession of northern kings, with their coups, until Ahab and Jezebel brought Baal worship into the heart of Israel. The week taught that a proud word can tear a nation, that convenient religion is idolatry, and that God keeps his promises to David even when his people do not keep theirs.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Rehoboam refused the counsel of the elders. Who are the wise people in your life, and are you listening to them?

God kept a lamp burning for David’s sake even when Judah’s kings failed. How does Christ, the true Son of David, give you confidence that God keeps his promises?

Jeroboam designed a religion that was convenient. Where are you tempted to adjust your faith to fit your comfort?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God you trust him with all your heart, and name one thing you lean on yourself for.

Thank him for keeping his promises to David and for Christ the true king.

Rest in him today.

DAY 337 · WEEK 49

Psalm 42

As a deer pants for flowing streams

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 42. It is the cry of a person who longs for God in a time of depression and exile. Pay attention to how the psalmist talks to his own soul.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 42 opens Book II of the Psalter and is attributed to the sons of Korah. The psalmist is far from the temple, "from the land of Jordan and of Hermon," in the far north. He is cut off from worship and surrounded by taunts. Placed here, at the beginning of the divided kingdom, it speaks for believers who feel the loss of the true worship of God. Psalms 42 and 43 are really one poem with a repeated refrain.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "As a deer pants for flowing streams, so pants my soul for you, O God" (v. 1).
2. "My soul thirsts for God, for the living God. When shall I come and appear before God?" (v. 2).
3. "My tears have been my food day and night, while they say to me all the day long, Where is your God?" (v. 3).
4. "These things I remember, as I pour out my soul: how I would go with the throng and lead them in procession to the house of God" (v. 4).
5. "Why are you cast down, O my soul, and why are you in turmoil within me? Hope in God; for I shall again praise him, my salvation and my God" (v. 5).
6. "Deep calls to deep at the roar of your waterfalls; all your breakers and your waves have gone over me" (v. 7).

7. “By day the LORD commands his steadfast love, and at night his song is with me, a prayer to the God of my life” (v. 8).

8. “I say to God, my rock: Why have you forgotten me?” (v. 9).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with one of the most beautiful images in the Bible: a deer in a drought, panting for water. The word “pants” conveys urgency. The animal’s life depends on finding a stream. The psalmist’s soul feels the same need for God. It is not a mild interest in religion. It is a thirst that cannot be satisfied by anything else.

The cause of his pain is twofold. First, he is cut off from the community of worshipers. He remembers going with the crowd to the house of God, with shouts of joy and thanksgiving. Now it is only a memory. Second, he faces mockery: “Where is your God?” The question is cruel because the psalmist himself half wonders. In times of suffering, God’s absence feels real.

What the psalmist does next is crucial. He talks to himself. “Why are you cast down, O my soul?” He does not simply give in to his feelings. He questions them. He addresses his soul as a person to be instructed. And he gives it an instruction: “Hope in God.” The refrain appears three times in Psalms 42 and 43, as though the psalmist must say it over and over. Faith is sometimes a matter of preaching to oneself.

Verse 7 is one of the most haunting: “Deep calls to deep.” The waves of trouble come one after another, and he feels submerged. But even there, God has not left. “By day the LORD commands his steadfast love, and at night his song is with me.” In the midst of the flood, there is a song. The psalmist does not claim to feel better, but he affirms where hope lies.

He does not hide the hard question: “Why have you forgotten me?” Honest prayer includes honest questions. And he answers them not with explanations but with the refrain: “Hope in God.”

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “If anyone thirsts, let him come to me and drink” (John 7:37), and he promised the woman at the well living water (John 4:10-14). He experienced forsakenness on the cross for our sake (Matthew 27:46). Revelation 7:17 promises that the Lamb “will guide them to springs of living water.” Peter calls us to hope in God through Christ (1 Peter 1:21). Jesus himself said, “My soul is very sorrowful” (Matthew 26:38).

STEP 6

Application

Preach to yourself today. Take the refrain, “Hope in God,” and speak it to your soul.

Remember a time of joyful worship, and let it feed your longing.

Bring your honest question, “Why?” to God. Do not stop at the question; add the hope.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what your soul thirsts for.
- Ask him to teach you to hope in him when you are cast down.
- Ask him for his steadfast love by day and song by night.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 49

“And when all the people saw it, they fell on their faces and said, The LORD, he is God; the LORD, he is God.”

1 KINGS 18:39

DAY 338 · WEEK 49

Psalm 43

Send out your light and your truth

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Psalm · 5 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 43. It is the second half of the poem you began yesterday. Notice how the psalmist asks for light and truth, and how he moves toward the altar of God.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 43 has no title in the Hebrew, and many manuscripts join it with Psalm 42 as a single poem. It shares the same refrain. The first psalm described the longing, and this psalm makes the request. The psalmist is surrounded by deceitful people, and he asks God to vindicate him and bring him back to worship.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Vindicate me, O God, and defend my cause against an ungodly people" (v. 1).
2. "From the deceitful and unjust man deliver me!" (v. 1).
3. "For you are the God in whom I take refuge; why have you rejected me?" (v. 2).
4. "Why do I go about mourning because of the oppression of the enemy?" (v. 2).
5. "Send out your light and your truth; let them lead me; let them bring me to your holy hill and to your dwelling!" (v. 3).
6. "Then I will go to the altar of God, to God my exceeding joy" (v. 4).
7. "And I will praise you with the lyre, O God, my God" (v. 4).
8. "Why are you cast down, O my soul, and why are you in turmoil within me? Hope in God; for I shall again praise him, my salvation and my God" (v. 5).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Where Psalm 42 was a lament, Psalm 43 is a petition. The psalmist asks God to be his advocate. He is in the middle of a case, and he wants God to judge between him and his enemies. He does not take revenge. He asks for vindication, for God to set things right.

Verse 2 repeats the question from Psalm 42:9: "Why have you rejected me?" The psalmist is honest about how it feels. He knows that God is his refuge, and yet he feels abandoned. The two statements sit side by side. This is not contradiction. It is the real experience of believers who have faith but not yet sight.

Verse 3 is the center of the poem: "Send out your light and your truth." The psalmist treats God's light and truth as if they were two messengers who could be dispatched to lead him. They are personified, almost like angels. Light shows the way, and truth keeps him from deception. He needs both. When surrounded by lies, he asks for truth. When in darkness, he asks for light.

Where do they lead? To God's holy hill, his dwelling place. The psalmist's goal is not just rescue but worship. He wants to return to the altar and to "God my exceeding joy." Literally, "the gladness of my joy." God himself is the source of the psalmist's deepest happiness. He wants to be where God is.

The refrain returns for a third time. It is almost stubborn. "Hope in God; for I shall again praise him." The "again" is important. The psalmist is confident that the dry time will end and that praise will return.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the light and truth that God sent. "I am the light of the world" (John 8:12) and "I am the way, and the truth, and the life" (John 14:6). "Grace and truth came through Jesus Christ" (John 1:17). Hebrews 10:19-22 shows that through Christ we have access to God's presence, the "altar" the psalmist longed for. Jesus is our advocate with the Father (1 John 2:1).

STEP 6

Application

Pray verse 3 for a specific situation: "Send out your light and your truth."

Ask God to lead you to his dwelling, to a deeper experience of worship.

Say the refrain aloud, "Hope in God," and add "for I shall again praise him."

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to send out his light and truth to lead you.
- Tell him that he is your exceeding joy.
- Tell your soul to hope in him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 49

"And when all the people saw it, they fell on their faces and said, The LORD, he is God; the LORD, he is God."

1 KINGS 18:39

DAY 339 · WEEK 49

1 Kings 17:1-19:21

Elijah, drought, Zarephath, Carmel, Horeb

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 73 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Kings 17:1-19:21. These are the great chapters about Elijah: the drought, the widow of Zarephath, the showdown on Mount Carmel, and the quiet voice on Mount Horeb. Read them slowly, and pay attention to what God does at each stage.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Under Ahab and Jezebel, Baal worship has been established as the official religion in Israel. Baal was a Canaanite storm and fertility god, credited with sending rain. Into this setting steps Elijah the Tishbite, a prophet from Gilead. His name means "my God is Yahweh." He announces a drought, and the confrontation is on: which God controls the rain?

STEP 3

Observation

1. "As the LORD, the God of Israel, lives, before whom I stand, there shall be neither dew nor rain these years, except by my word" (17:1).
2. The LORD sends Elijah to the brook Cherith, where ravens bring him bread and meat (17:2-6).
3. At Zarephath, a widow gives Elijah her last meal, and "the jar of flour was not spent, neither did the jug of oil become empty" (17:8-16).
4. Elijah raises the widow's son, and she says, "Now I know that you are a man of God, and that the word of the LORD in your mouth is truth" (17:17-24).
5. "How long will you go limping between two different opinions? If the LORD is God, follow him; but if Baal, then follow him" (18:21).

6. Baal's prophets cry out from morning to evening, but "there was no voice. No one answered" (18:26-29).
7. "Then the fire of the LORD fell and consumed the burnt offering"; the people said, "The LORD, he is God; the LORD, he is God" (18:38-39).
8. At Horeb, God is not in the wind, earthquake, or fire, but in "a low whisper" (19:11-12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The drought is a direct challenge to Baal. The god of the storm cannot bring rain, and the LORD controls the weather. But the first part of Elijah's ministry takes place away from the public eye. He hides at Cherith, fed by ravens, and then goes to Zarephath, in Sidon, the homeland of Jezebel. The God of Israel is caring for a foreign widow and her son, and showing that his power reaches beyond Israel. Jesus will point to this very story (Luke 4:25-26).

The showdown at Carmel is the center of the passage. Elijah does not ask the people for loyalty to God alone. He asks them to decide: "How long will you go limping between two opinions?" Divided loyalty is not neutrality. It is a form of unfaithfulness. The contest is simple. The god who answers by fire is God. Baal's prophets cry and cut themselves all day. Nothing happens. Elijah mocks them, "Cry aloud, for he is a god." Then he rebuilds the LORD's altar with twelve stones, representing all Israel, soaks it with water three times, and prays a short prayer. Fire falls. The people declare, "The LORD, he is God."

Then comes an odd turn. After the greatest victory of his life, Elijah runs in fear from Jezebel's threat. He sits under a broom tree and asks to die. "It is enough; now, O LORD, take my life." The prophet who stood boldly on Carmel is now exhausted, depressed, and alone. God's response is gentle. He lets Elijah sleep and sends an angel with food. The first thing God offers is rest and a meal.

At Horeb, the same mountain where Moses met God, Elijah expects power. Wind, earthquake, and fire pass, but the LORD is not in them. Then a low whisper. The God of fire is also the God of the quiet voice. And he tells Elijah that he is not alone: seven thousand in Israel have not bowed to Baal. He gives him work to do, including calling Elisha.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus cited the widow of Zarephath in his first sermon (Luke 4:25-26). John the Baptist came "in the spirit and power of Elijah" (Luke 1:17), and Jesus said Elijah had already come (Matthew 17:11-13). Jesus fed the five thousand, a greater miracle of provision. He raised a

widow's son at Nain (Luke 7:11-17). At the transfiguration, Elijah appeared with Moses to speak with Jesus (Luke 9:30). Romans 11:2-5 uses the story of the seven thousand to show that God always keeps a remnant.

STEP 6

Application

Where are you limping between two opinions? Make your decision today.

If you are exhausted after a hard season, remember that God first gave Elijah food and sleep.

Listen for the low whisper of God in the quiet today.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to keep you from limping between two opinions.
- Tell him where you are weary, and ask him to feed and rest you.
- Listen for his whisper and tell him what you hear.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 49

"And when all the people saw it, they fell on their faces and said, The LORD, he is God; the LORD, he is God."

1 KINGS 18:39

DAY 340 · WEEK 49

1 Kings 20:1-22:53

Ahab's wars; Naboth's vineyard; Jehoshaphat

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 103 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 1 Kings 20:1-22:53. Ahab's wars with Syria, the story of Naboth's vineyard, and the death of Ahab are told here. Notice the way God uses prophets to confront the king, and the key difference between the true prophet Micaiah and the 400 who tell the king what he wants to hear.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After Carmel, Ahab remains king, and the chapters that follow show him at war with Syria and in conflict with the prophets. The story of Naboth's vineyard is one of the most disturbing accounts of abuse of power in Scripture. The section ends with an alliance between Ahab and Jehoshaphat, the godly king of Judah, and a battle at Ramoth-gilead where Ahab dies.

STEP 3

Observation

1. A prophet tells Ahab that God will give him victory over the Syrians "that you may know that I am the LORD" (20:13).
2. The Syrians say, "The LORD is a god of the hills but he is not a god of the valleys," and God defeats them again (20:28).
3. Ahab spares Ben-hadad, and a prophet says, "Your life shall be for his life" (20:34-42).
4. Naboth refuses to sell his vineyard: "The LORD forbid that I should give you the inheritance of my fathers" (21:3).
5. Jezebel arranges false witnesses and has Naboth stoned (21:5-14).
6. Elijah confronts Ahab: "Have you killed and also taken possession?" (21:19).

7. Ahab humbles himself, and God delays the disaster (21:27-29).
8. The prophet Micaiah says, “As the LORD lives, what the LORD says to me, that I will speak” (22:14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 20 shows God’s patience with Ahab. Twice he gives him victory over a stronger enemy, so that Ahab will know that God is the LORD. The Syrians’ belief that the LORD is a god of the hills only is corrected. His power is not limited by geography. Yet Ahab fails to follow through, making a treaty with a man God had devoted to destruction.

Chapter 21 shows what power does when it ignores God. Ahab wants a vineyard. Naboth refuses on principle: it is his family’s inheritance, given under the covenant law (Leviticus 25:23). Ahab goes home to sulk. Jezebel takes over, forges letters, arranges a show trial with false witnesses, and Naboth is killed. The scene mimics a legal process while committing murder. When Ahab comes to take the vineyard, Elijah is waiting. “Have you killed and also taken possession?” This is one of the great confrontations of the Bible. A prophet stands against a king to defend the rights of a poor man.

Naboth’s story shows that God cares about justice, property, and truth. The abuse of the weak by the powerful is not outside his concern. The prophets will return to this theme in Amos and Micah, which you will read later in this unit.

The most surprising detail is that Ahab humbles himself when he hears the judgment. He tears his clothes and fasts. And God sees it, and delays the disaster to the next generation. The mercy of God is wide. Even a wicked man’s partial repentance is noticed.

In chapter 22, Ahab asks 400 prophets whether to go to battle. They all say yes. Jehoshaphat asks, “Is there not here another prophet of the LORD?” Micaiah is the one prophet who says what God says, and it is bad news. He stands alone against the crowd. The story ends with Ahab disguised in battle, struck by a random arrow, and dying as the prophets said. The word of the LORD stands.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus, too, stood alone before a crowd and spoke the truth. He defended the vulnerable and confronted powerful men (Matthew 23). The false witnesses at Naboth’s trial recall the false witnesses against Jesus (Matthew 26:59-61). Jesus said, “Woe to you when all people speak well of you, for so their fathers did to the false prophets” (Luke 6:26). Hebrews 11:36-38 speaks of the faithful who suffered for the truth.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether you are listening to the voices that tell you what you want to hear.

Think about someone who has less power than you. Are you protecting them?

Speak the truth in love this week, even when it is costly.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he sees the poor and hears the cry of the wronged.

Ask him for the courage of Micaiah to speak what he says.

Ask him to keep you from the chorus of flatterers.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 49

"And when all the people saw it, they fell on their faces and said, The LORD, he is God; the LORD, he is God."

1 KINGS 18:39

DAY 341 · WEEK 49

2 Kings 1:1-2:25

Elijah taken up; Elisha receives the mantle

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 43 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Kings 1:1-2:25. Elijah's ministry ends in a whirlwind, and Elisha takes up his mantle. Notice the careful details about the crossing of the Jordan and the request for a double portion.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The book of 2 Kings begins where 1 Kings ended, with Ahab's death and his son Ahaziah on the throne. Elijah's final acts include a confrontation over consulting a foreign god. Then the narrative turns to the transition from Elijah to Elisha, one of the most dramatic passages in the Old Testament. The crossing of the Jordan recalls Joshua and the exodus.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Ahaziah sends messengers to inquire of Baal-zebub, and Elijah says, "Is it because there is no God in Israel that you are going to inquire of Baal-zebub?" (1:3).
2. Fire falls from heaven on two companies of fifty, but the third captain pleads for his life (1:9-15).
3. Elijah and Elisha cross the Jordan on dry ground when Elijah strikes the water with his cloak (2:8).
4. Elisha says, "Please let there be a double portion of your spirit on me" (2:9).
5. "And behold, chariots of fire and horses of fire separated the two of them. And Elijah went up by a whirlwind into heaven" (2:11).
6. Elisha cries, "My father, my father! The chariots of Israel and its horsemen!" (2:12).

7. Elisha takes up Elijah's cloak and asks, "Where is the LORD, the God of Elijah?" and strikes the water, and it parts (2:13-14).

8. The sons of the prophets say, "The spirit of Elijah rests on Elisha" (2:15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 1 shows once again the foolishness of seeking help from other gods. Ahaziah is ill and sends to Baal-zebub, the god of Ekron. The question Elijah asks is blunt: "Is it because there is no God in Israel?" It is a rebuke to all who treat the true God as one option among many. The fire episode is dramatic and shows the seriousness of opposing God's prophet. The third captain's humble approach is the one that finds mercy.

Chapter 2 is the high point. Elijah is about to be taken, and Elisha will not leave him. Three times Elijah tells him to stay behind, and three times Elisha refuses. His loyalty and persistence are remarkable. When Elijah asks what he can do for him, Elisha does not ask for wealth or safety. He asks for a double portion of Elijah's spirit, the share of the firstborn son. He wants to be Elijah's heir and to continue his ministry.

The departure of Elijah is one of two times in the Old Testament that someone is taken to heaven without dying (the other is Enoch). Chariots and horses of fire appear, a vision of the heavenly army. Elisha's cry, "My father, my father!" acknowledges Elijah as a spiritual father and as Israel's real defense. The chariots of Israel are not its armies but its prophets.

Then Elisha takes the cloak, steps to the Jordan, and asks the question that sums up the whole passage: "Where is the LORD, the God of Elijah?" The prophet is gone, but God remains. The waters part. Elisha is not Elijah, but the same God is with him.

The chapter ends with a hard episode: boys mock Elisha and are attacked by bears. This is not about baldness. It is about contempt for God's prophet, and the seriousness of mocking God's word.

STEP 5

Connection

John the Baptist came in the spirit and power of Elijah (Luke 1:17). Jesus ascended into heaven, taken up before the eyes of his disciples (Acts 1:9-11), and sent the Spirit on them. The "double portion" finds its fulfillment at Pentecost. Hebrews 2:2-4 warns against ignoring a greater salvation. Jesus crossed from death to life and opened the way for all his people.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether you want a double portion of God's Spirit, and what you would do with it.

Practice Elisha's persistence in following a spiritual mentor.

When someone you depend on is taken from you, ask, "Where is the LORD, the God of Elijah?" and trust that he remains.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to give you a hunger for his Spirit.
- Thank him that he remains when those who guide you are gone.
- Ask him to keep you from mocking what he sends.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 49

"And when all the people saw it, they fell on their faces and said, The LORD, he is God; the LORD, he is God."

1 KINGS 18:39

DAY 342 · WEEK 49

2 Kings 3:1-4:44

Moab defeated; Elisha's miracles begin

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 56 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Kings 3:1-4:44. Elisha's ministry begins with the defeat of Moab and a series of miracles of provision and restoration. Look for how these miracles echo the work of Elijah and anticipate the work of Jesus.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Elisha begins his ministry under King Jehoram of Israel, son of Ahab. A coalition of Israel, Judah, and Edom marches against Moab and nearly dies of thirst. Elisha is called, and God provides. Chapter 4 follows with four miracles in the lives of ordinary people: a widow's oil, a Shunammite woman's son, a poisoned stew, and a feeding of one hundred men.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The three kings are without water, and Jehoshaphat asks, "Is there no prophet of the LORD here, through whom we may inquire of the LORD?" (3:11).
2. Elisha says, "You shall not see wind or rain, but that streambed shall be filled with water" (3:17).
3. The Moabite king sacrifices his son on the wall, and "there came great wrath against Israel" (3:27).
4. A widow cries, "Your servant my husband is dead… and the creditor has come to take my two children," and Elisha multiplies her oil (4:1-7).
5. A woman of Shunem builds a room for Elisha, and God gives her a son (4:8-17).
6. The boy dies, and the woman says, "It is well," and Elisha raises him (4:18-37).

7. Elisha purifies a poisoned stew: “Then bring flour… and there was no harm in the pot” (4:38-41).

8. He feeds a hundred men with twenty loaves, “For thus says the LORD, They shall eat and have some left” (4:42-44).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 3 shows God’s mercy to a flawed alliance. Jehoram is no friend of the LORD, but because of Jehoshaphat, Elisha speaks. The water arrives not by rain but by a miracle, and in the morning the sun on the water looks like blood to the Moabites. The victory is God’s gift. The ending is strange and grim: the king of Moab sacrifices his own son, and Israel withdraws. The chapter shows how dark pagan religion could be.

Chapter 4 turns to the ordinary lives of the poor. The widow is about to lose her sons to a creditor. She has only a jar of oil. Elisha tells her to borrow empty vessels, as many as she can, and the oil flows until all the jars are full. God’s provision is limited only by her faith and the number of jars. It is a picture of grace that meets need and overflows.

The Shunammite woman is a model of hospitality. She sees that Elisha is a holy man and builds a small room for him. When she receives a promise of a son, she is incredulous. And when the boy dies, she says, “It is well.” Her faith is mixed with grief, but she goes straight to the man of God. Elisha stretches himself over the boy and he lives. It is the first account of resurrection in the Old Testament after Elijah’s raising of the widow’s son.

The last two miracles are simple. Death in the pot is turned to food, and a small gift of bread feeds a hundred men with some left over. The theme is the same: in a land of famine and idolatry, God’s word brings life and provision. The “sons of the prophets” are fed because of the faithfulness of a few.

Elisha’s miracles are works of mercy. They are directed at the vulnerable. They show what kind of God the LORD is: one who sees the needs of the poor.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus did every one of these miracles on a larger scale. He fed the five thousand with five loaves and two fish, “and they all ate and were satisfied” (Luke 9:12-17). He raised a widow’s son (Luke 7:11-17), and Jairus’s daughter (Luke 8:49-56). He turned water into wine (John 2). He said, “I am the bread of life” (John 6:35). Elisha’s miracles point to the One who has power over death and hunger.

STEP 6

Application

Ask God to show you your “empty jars,” places where you need his provision. Bring them in faith.

Practice hospitality, as the Shunammite did. Whom can you welcome?

When you face a loss, say with the Shunammite, “It is well,” as an act of trust, even through grief.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what vessels in your life feel empty.
- Ask him to teach you hospitality.
- Thank him that you can say “It is well” in sorrow.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 49

“And when all the people saw it, they fell on their faces and said, The LORD, he is God; the LORD, he is God.”

1 KINGS 18:39

DAY 343 · WEEK 49

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 1 Kings 18:39 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"And when all the people saw it, they fell on their faces and said, The LORD, he is God; the LORD, he is God."

1 KINGS 18:39

REST

Meditation

This is the people's response on Mount Carmel after fire falls from heaven. It is a simple confession, repeated for emphasis, and it is the heart of what the prophets were sent to say.

"When all the people saw it." They had been standing on the fence. Elijah asked them how long they would go limping between two opinions, and they had said nothing. Now they see. God does not always answer prayer with fire from heaven, but when he acts, his people recognize it.

"They fell on their faces." This is the posture of worship and of surrender. It is not a casual nod of agreement. They are overwhelmed. They realize that they have been wrong.

"The LORD, he is God." This is the confession that Israel was made for. The Hebrew is emphatic: Yahweh, he is the God. It echoes the Shema: "The LORD our God, the LORD is one." And it echoes Elijah's own name, "My God is Yahweh." All of Elijah's mission is encapsulated

in this sentence.

"The LORD, he is God." The repetition is the people's way of saying it with their whole heart. They say it twice because they cannot say it enough.

In the days of the divided kingdom, the question was always, "Who is God?" Baal or the LORD? Money or the LORD? The king or the LORD? The same question faces us. This verse is an invitation to make the confession again. Not just once, but daily. The LORD, he is God. Christ is Lord (Philippians 2:11). Say it when you are tempted to serve something else.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you followed the divided kingdom into the age of Elijah and Elisha. You read Psalms 42 and 43, the cry of a soul thirsting for God, with the refrain "Hope in God." You saw Elijah announce the drought, be fed by ravens, and confront the prophets of Baal on Carmel, where fire fell and the people confessed, "The LORD, he is God." You saw the same prophet, exhausted and afraid, meet God in a low whisper at Horeb. You read the story of Naboth's vineyard, and the lone prophet Micaiah. You watched Elijah taken to heaven and Elisha take up the mantle, and you read the miracles of Elisha for widows, a Shunammite, and the hungry. The week taught that God is the one true God, that he cares for the weak, and that he speaks even in whispers.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Elijah moved from triumph on Carmel to despair under the broom tree. How does God's gentle care of him encourage you in a season of exhaustion?

Elisha's miracles of provision and resurrection point to Jesus, the bread of life and the conqueror of death. Which of these miracles speaks most to a need you have right now?

Naboth was wronged by the powerful, and God sent a prophet to defend him. Who in your world needs someone to speak up for them?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God that the LORD, he is God, and why you say it.

Thank him for answering by fire and speaking in a whisper.

Thank him for caring for the poor and grieving.

DAY 344 · WEEK 50

Psalm 44

We have not forgotten you, communal lament

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Psalm · 26 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 44. This is a corporate lament, the prayer of a whole people who feel abandoned by God even though they have been faithful. Notice that the psalm does not confess a sin. Read it with those who suffer innocently.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 44 is a psalm of the sons of Korah. It reflects a time of national defeat: the army has been routed, the people scattered, and the nation mocked. We do not know the exact occasion. It fits any period of national humiliation, and it has been prayed by God's people in many centuries. Here, in the age of the divided kingdom, it gives voice to the faithful in a time of judgment.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "O God, we have heard with our ears, our fathers have told us, what deeds you performed in their days" (v. 1).
2. "For not by their own sword did they win the land, nor did their own arm save them, but your right hand and your arm" (v. 3).
3. "In God we have boasted continually, and we will give thanks to your name forever" (v. 8).
4. "But you have rejected us and disgraced us and have not gone out with our armies" (v. 9).
5. "You have made us like sheep for slaughter and have scattered us among the nations" (v. 11).

6. “All this has come upon us, though we have not forgotten you, and we have not been false to your covenant” (v. 17).
7. “Yet for your sake we are killed all the day long; we are regarded as sheep to be slaughtered” (v. 22).
8. “Awake! Why are you sleeping, O Lord? Rouse yourself! Do not reject us forever!” (v. 23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with memory. The people recall what God did for their ancestors in the conquest. They know that victory was God’s gift, not their own achievement. This is the foundation of their confidence: God has acted before.

Then comes the shock of verse 9, marked by the word “But.” The God who gave them victory has now rejected them. The psalm describes the defeat in blunt terms. The army is routed. The people are sold for nothing. Neighbors mock. The psalmist feels deep shame.

The most striking feature is the claim of innocence. “All this has come upon us, though we have not forgotten you.” Unlike many laments, there is no confession of sin. The people say that they have been faithful. Whether this is a claim of perfection or a statement about their covenant loyalty in general, the psalm expresses the experience of suffering that is not explained by wrongdoing. The Bible allows for this. Not every hardship is a punishment. Sometimes the righteous suffer, and the psalm lets them say so.

The language of the closing verses is bold. “Awake! Why are you sleeping, O Lord?” It is not irreverence. It is the language of covenant. The people are saying, “You promised to be with us. Where are you?” They have no explanation, only an appeal: “Redeem us for the sake of your steadfast love.” The final plea rests on God’s character. It is not their merit but his covenant love that gives them hope.

Verse 22 is quoted by Paul in Romans 8:36, and he applies it to the experience of believers: “For your sake we are killed all the day long.” He then declares, “In all these things we are more than conquerors through him who loved us.” The psalm’s question is answered in Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul quotes verse 22 in Romans 8:36 and answers the psalm’s cry with the assurance that nothing can separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus (Romans 8:37-39). Jesus is the Lamb led to slaughter (Isaiah 53:7; Acts 8:32). 2 Corinthians 4:8-11 describes the suffering of

the faithful. Jesus himself cried, “Why have you forsaken me?” (Matthew 27:46), taking the experience of abandonment on himself.

STEP 6

Application

If you are suffering though you have been faithful, pray this psalm. God hears the cry that does not explain.

Recall what God has done for your ancestors in faith, and tell it to someone younger.

Read Romans 8:31-39 alongside this psalm and hold both.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what he has done in days of old that you cling to.
- Ask him to rise up and help.
- Thank him that nothing can separate you from his love.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 50

“Do not fear, for those who are with us are more than those who are with them.”

2 KINGS 6:16

DAY 345 · WEEK 50

Psalm 60

O God, you have rejected us

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 60. David prays after a military setback and ends with confidence in God. Notice the movement from complaint to promise to prayer.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The title of Psalm 60 places it in a time when David fought Aram and Edom, and Joab struck down 12,000 Edomites in the Valley of Salt (see 2 Samuel 8). It reflects an initial defeat before the victory. It follows Psalm 44 as a second corporate lament, but ends with more resolve. It is a prayer of a king and nation that have been shaken.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "O God, you have rejected us, broken our defenses; you have been angry; oh, restore us" (v. 1).
2. "You have made the land to quake; you have torn it open; repair its breaches, for it totters" (v. 2).
3. "You have made your people see hard things; you have given us wine to drink that made us stagger" (v. 3).
4. "You have set up a banner for those who fear you, that they may flee to it from the bow" (v. 4).
5. "That your beloved ones may be delivered, give salvation by your right hand and answer us!" (v. 5).
6. "God has spoken in his holiness: With exultation I will divide up Shechem" (v. 6).
7. "Oh grant us help against the foe, for vain is the salvation of man!" (v. 11).

8 “With God we shall do valiantly; it is he who will tread down our foes” (v. 12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with the same bewildering confession as Psalm 44: God has rejected us. But here, the language is of an earthquake. The land has cracked open. The structure of national life is shaking. The psalmist does not blame bad luck or strategy. He sees God’s hand in it. This may seem harsh, but it is also a comfort: if God broke it, God can repair it. “Repair its breaches, for it totters.” The one who allowed the crack is the only one who can mend it.

The image of the wine that makes people stagger is strong. God has made his people drink a cup of reeling. They have “seen hard things.” The Bible does not shy away from the fact that God’s people sometimes go through suffering that disorients them.

Yet verse 4 offers a turn: “You have set up a banner for those who fear you.” A banner is a rallying point in battle. God provides a place to gather. In the midst of defeat, there is a standard to flee to. For those who fear him, he is both the one who shakes and the one who shelters.

Then, in verses 6 to 8, God speaks. His voice cuts through the confusion. He claims Shechem, Succoth, Gilead, Manasseh, Ephraim, and Judah as his. Moab, Edom, and Philistia are described as his washbasin, his sandal, and his subjects. Everything belongs to him. The promise of God’s word is the foundation of the king’s confidence.

The final prayer is one of the best in the Bible for a time of need: “Oh grant us help against the foe, for vain is the salvation of man!” Human help is empty. “With God we shall do valiantly.” The psalm ends in confidence, not because circumstances changed, but because the speaker has remembered who God is.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says, “If God is for us, who can be against us?” (Romans 8:31). Jesus is the banner raised for the nations (Isaiah 11:10; John 12:32). 2 Corinthians 12:9-10 shows strength made perfect in weakness. Psalm 108:6-13 repeats this psalm’s final section. 1 Corinthians 15:57: “Thanks be to God, who gives us the victory through our Lord Jesus Christ.”

STEP 6

Application

If something in your life feels like an earthquake, ask God to repair the breach.

Look for the “banner” God has set up for you, whether it is his word, his church, or his promise.

Pray verse 12 today: “With God we shall do valiantly.”

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to repair what has been shaken in your life.
- Admit that human help is vain, and ask for his.
- Thank him that with him we shall do valiantly.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 50

“Do not fear, for those who are with us are more than those who are with them.”

2 KINGS 6:16

DAY 346 · WEEK 50

2 Kings 5:1-6:33

Naaman healed; Gehazi's greed; the Syrian siege

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 60 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Kings 5:1-6:33. Naaman the Syrian is healed of leprosy, Gehazi's greed is judged, and Elisha is surrounded by an army and sees a greater one. Read the story of Naaman as a picture of grace that humbles.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Elisha's ministry extends to foreigners. Naaman is a commander of the Syrian army, Israel's enemy, and a leper. Through the witness of a captured Israelite girl, he comes to the prophet. These chapters include one of the Bible's best stories of grace, followed by a sad story of greed, and the account of the Syrian siege of Samaria.

STEP 3

Observation

1. A little Israelite girl says to Naaman's wife, "Would that my lord were with the prophet who is in Samaria! He would cure him of his leprosy" (5:3).
2. Elisha sends a messenger: "Go and wash in the Jordan seven times, and your flesh shall be restored" (5:10).
3. Naaman is angry: "Behold, I thought that he would surely come out to me" (5:11).
4. His servants say, "If the prophet had commanded you to do some great thing, would you not have done it?" (5:13).
5. "His flesh was restored like the flesh of a little child, and he was clean" (5:14).
6. Naaman says, "Behold, I know that there is no God in all the earth but in Israel" (5:15).
7. Gehazi takes a gift Elisha refused, and Naaman's leprosy clings to him (5:20-27).
8. "Do not fear, for those who are with us are more than those who are with them" (6:16).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The story begins with a nameless girl. She is a captive and a servant, with every reason to be bitter. Yet she wishes her master's health and points him to the prophet. A small voice of faith makes a large difference. God uses the unnoticed.

Naaman comes with horses, chariots, silver, gold, and a letter from a king. He expects a spectacle. Elisha does not even come out. He sends a messenger with a plain instruction: wash in the Jordan. Naaman is furious. The muddy Jordan seems beneath him. He wanted to be healed on his own terms, in a way that honored his status. It is a picture of pride that resists grace. His servants help him see sense: "If he had commanded you to do some great thing, would you not have done it? How much more, when he says to you, Wash, and be clean?" The simplicity of the remedy was the offense.

When he humbles himself and obeys, he is healed and his skin becomes like a child's. He confesses the LORD as the only God. It is a conversion. He asks to take two mule-loads of earth, so that he can worship the LORD in Syria.

The contrast with Gehazi is sharp. Gehazi, who has been with the prophet and seen miracles, sees an opportunity to profit from grace. He lies to get the gift. The leprosy of Naaman passes to him. The outsider is cleansed, and the insider is judged. Proximity to God's work is no substitute for faith.

Chapter 6 gives a different scene. The Syrian army surrounds Elisha's city. His servant is terrified. Elisha prays, and the servant's eyes are opened to see the hills full of horses and chariots of fire. The unseen world is real. And Elisha's unusual response to the captured Syrian army is to feed them and send them home. "And the Syrians no more came on raids." Kindness did what swords could not.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus used Naaman's story in his sermon at Nazareth (Luke 4:27), pointing out that God's mercy reaches the Gentiles. Baptism is a washing that seems simple but is a sign of cleansing by grace (Titus 3:5). Romans 12:20-21 says to feed your enemy and overcome evil with good. Jesus told his disciples, "Do not be afraid, little flock" (Luke 12:32), and Revelation 5:11 shows the heavenly host surrounding the throne. 1 Timothy 6:10 warns of the love of money, as seen in Gehazi.

STEP 6

Application

Ask where pride keeps you from receiving grace in a simple form.

Think about the “little girl” in your life who points you to God. Thank them.

Pray for the eyes of your heart to be opened, as Elisha prayed for his servant.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to humble your pride so that you can receive his grace in the simple way he gives it.

Thank him for the little ones who point to him.

Ask him to open your eyes to see his armies around you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 50

“Do not fear, for those who are with us are more than those who are with them.”

2 KINGS 6:16

DAY 347 · WEEK 50

2 Kings 7:1-8:29

The siege lifted; Elisha's prophecies fulfilled

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 52 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Kings 7:1-8:29. The siege of Samaria is lifted by four lepers, and Elisha's prophecies are fulfilled. Notice how God's word comes true in unexpected ways, and the quiet sadness of Elisha's meeting with Hazael.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Samaria is under siege by the Syrians, and the famine is so severe that people are eating the unthinkable. In the middle of the despair, Elisha announces that by tomorrow, food will be cheap. The chapter that follows tells how God does it. In chapter 8, the story widens to include the Shunammite woman's land and the beginning of Hazael's reign in Syria.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Elisha says, "Hear the word of the LORD: thus says the LORD, Tomorrow about this time a seah of fine flour shall be sold for a shekel" (7:1).
2. The king's officer says, "If the LORD himself should make windows in heaven, could this thing be?" (7:2).
3. Four lepers at the gate say, "Why are we sitting here until we die?" (7:3).
4. They find the Syrian camp abandoned: the LORD had made the army hear the sound of chariots and horses (7:6-7).
5. "We are not doing right. This day is a day of good news. If we are silent and wait until the morning light, punishment will overtake us. Now therefore come, let us go and tell" (7:9).
6. "And the people went out and plundered the camp of the Syrians" (7:16).

7. The officer who doubted is trampled at the gate and dies (7:17-20).
8. Elisha weeps before Hazael: “I know the evil that you will do to the people of Israel” (8:11-12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The chapter turns on a surprising set of heroes. Four lepers, outcasts and untouchables, sitting outside the city gate, are the ones God uses to deliver Samaria. They have nothing to lose. They reason that if they stay, they die, and if they go to the Syrian camp, they may live. When they find the camp empty and full of food, they eat and hide treasure. Then their conscience speaks: “We are not doing right. This day is a day of good news.” They go to tell the city.

The scene is a picture of evangelism. The lepers did not earn the abundance. They were simply the first to discover it. Having received, they felt compelled to share. “This day is a day of good news.” The Greek word for gospel is “good news.” The image of beggars telling other beggars where to find bread is one that has been used to describe the gospel.

God’s word is fulfilled to the letter. The price of flour drops overnight, exactly as Elisha said. And the officer who scoffed, “Could this thing be?” sees it but does not eat of it. He is trampled in the rush at the gate. The word of the LORD does not fail, and unbelief has a cost.

In chapter 8, the story of the Shunammite’s land shows God’s providence in small things. She returns from famine exactly when the king is hearing Gehazi tell her story, and her land is restored. Timing is not an accident.

The meeting with Hazael is sobering. Elisha weeps when he sees what Hazael will do to Israel. Hazael, who calls himself a dog, will become a brutal king. Elisha does not rejoice in judgment. The prophet weeps over what God shows him. And the chapter ends with the continuing decline of Judah, which has now joined itself to Ahab’s family by marriage.

STEP 5

Connection

The four lepers’ discovery is a picture of the gospel: poor, outcast people finding a feast and telling others. Jesus said, “Freely you have received; freely give” (Matthew 10:8). Jesus healed lepers (Luke 17:11-19) and sent his disciples to proclaim the good news. Elisha’s tears over Israel recall Jesus’ tears over Jerusalem (Luke 19:41). Hebrews 4:2 warns that the message did not benefit those who did not share the faith.

STEP 6

Application

Think of someone who needs to hear good news. Tell them today.

Examine yourself for unbelief like the officer's, a "could this thing be?" attitude toward God's word.

Weep over what grieves God, as Elisha did over Israel.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for good news for the poor, and ask him to make you someone who cannot keep it to yourself.

Confess where his word has met your unbelief.

Tell him one person to share it with.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 50

"Do not fear, for those who are with us are more than those who are with them."

2 KINGS 6:16

DAY 348 · WEEK 50

2 Kings 9:1-10:36

Jehu's bloody reform, judgment on Ahab's house

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 73 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Kings 9:1-10:36. Jehu is anointed to destroy the house of Ahab. This is one of the most violent sections of the Bible. Read it as God's judgment on a house that had murdered Naboth and the prophets, and notice what Jehu fails to do.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

A young prophet sent by Elisha anoints Jehu, a commander in the army, as king of Israel. His mission is to carry out the judgment announced by Elijah on the house of Ahab, which had led Israel into Baal worship and shed innocent blood. The story is fast, bloody, and sobering. It shows both the seriousness of God's judgment and the limits of human zeal.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Thus says the LORD, the God of Israel, I anoint you king over the people of the LORD, over Israel" (9:6).
2. "You shall strike down the house of Ahab your master, that I may avenge on Jezebel the blood of my servants the prophets" (9:7).
3. Jehu says to Joram, "What peace can there be, so long as the whorings and the sorceries of your mother Jezebel are so many?" (9:22).
4. Jezebel is thrown from her window, and the dogs eat her, as Elijah had said (9:30-37).
5. Jehu has all seventy sons of Ahab killed (10:1-11).
6. Jehu says to Jehonadab, "Come with me, and see my zeal for the LORD" (10:16).
7. Jehu tricks the worshipers of Baal into the temple and kills them, and "Jehu wiped out Baal from Israel" (10:18-28).

8 “But Jehu was not careful to walk in the law of the LORD, the God of Israel, with all his heart. He did not turn from the sins of Jeroboam” (10:31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

This is a hard story to read. It is full of violence, and it is not easy to feel comfortable with it. The first thing to see is the context. Ahab’s house had killed Naboth, killed prophets, led the nation into idolatry, and ignored every warning. Elijah had announced judgment years before, and God had delayed because of Ahab’s humility. Now the delay is over. The word of the LORD is fulfilled to the letter: Jezebel is eaten by dogs, Ahab’s sons are killed, and Baal worship is purged.

The Bible does not present these events as a model for how believers should behave today. The church does not wield the sword. It is a record of God’s judgment against a specific house at a specific time, in the period of the old covenant, when Israel was a nation-state under God’s law.

The second thing to see is the flaw in Jehu. He is zealous, but his zeal is partial. He destroys Baal, but he does not turn from the golden calves of Jeroboam. He is efficient, but he also kills beyond what God commanded, and the prophet Hosea later criticizes the “blood of Jezreel” (Hosea 1:4). He says, “See my zeal for the LORD,” but he is also proud of it. Zeal without a whole heart is dangerous. Jehu cleans out one idol but keeps the other, and he does not love God with all his heart.

The summary verdict is one of the saddest in Kings: “Jehu was not careful to walk in the law of the LORD with all his heart.” God rewards his obedience with four generations of kings, but the decline continues. Partial reform is not enough.

The scene reminds us that God’s judgment is real. He does not overlook innocent blood. The judgment of Jezebel is the downfall of one who had killed prophets. And the passage invites us to examine whether our own obedience is whole-hearted.

STEP 5

Connection

Revelation 2:20 uses Jezebel as a symbol for false teaching in the church. Jesus is the king who will judge with righteousness, but who first took judgment on himself. Romans 12:19 reminds believers that vengeance belongs to God. Jesus rebuked James and John for wanting to call down fire (Luke 9:54-55). Matthew 22:37 calls us to love the LORD with all our heart, soul, and mind, the wholeheartedness Jehu lacked.

STEP 6

Application

Ask what you have removed from your life in the name of faith and what you have kept.

Examine whether your zeal is for God's glory or for your own reputation.

Thank God that judgment fell on Christ, so that mercy can reach even the worst sinner.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he is just and does not forget innocent blood.

Ask him for a whole heart, not partial reform.

Ask him to keep your zeal from pride.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 50

"Do not fear, for those who are with us are more than those who are with them."

2 KINGS 6:16

DAY 349 · WEEK 50

2 Kings 11:1-13:25

Athaliah; Joash; Jehoahaz

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 86 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Kings 11:1-13:25. Athaliah tries to destroy the line of David, and a child king is hidden and crowned. Watch how God preserves the Davidic line, and read the story of Elisha's death.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

In Judah, Ahaziah is killed by Jehu, and his mother Athaliah, the daughter of Ahab, seizes power by murdering the royal family. The Davidic line seems to be extinguished. In the north, the successors of Jehu rule under Syrian pressure. The section ends with the death of Elisha and a note about God's covenant faithfulness.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "When Athaliah the mother of Ahaziah saw that her son was dead, she arose and destroyed all the royal family" (11:1).
2. Jehosheba, Ahaziah's sister, takes baby Joash and hides him in the house of the LORD for six years (11:2-3).
3. The priest Jehoiada brings out the king's son, puts the crown on him, and anoints him, and they shout, "Long live the king!" (11:12).
4. "Then Jehoiada made a covenant between the LORD and the king and people, that they should be the LORD's people" (11:17).
5. The temple of Baal is torn down (11:18).
6. "And Jehoash did what was right in the eyes of the LORD all his days, because Jehoiada the priest instructed him" (12:2).

7. Jehoahaz seeks the LORD's favor, "and the LORD listened to him, for he saw the oppression of Israel" (13:4).
8. The LORD "was gracious to them and had compassion on them… because of his covenant with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob" (13:23).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Athaliah's rise is one of the darkest moments for Judah. She kills her own grandchildren to take the throne. The line of David, through which the promised Messiah is to come, is almost wiped out. It looks as though the covenant of 2 Samuel 7 has failed. But a woman named Jehosheba takes one baby, Joash, and hides him in the temple. For six years, while a murderous queen rules in Jerusalem, the hope of the world sleeps in a room in God's house.

It is a quiet picture of providence. God keeps his promises through the courage of ordinary people, a princess, a priest, a nurse. And in the seventh year, Jehoiada brings Joash out, surrounded by guards, and crowns him. The people clap their hands and shout, "Long live the king!" Athaliah, hearing the noise, cries "Treason!" and is put to death. The covenant is renewed: the king, the people, and the LORD.

Joash begins well. He repairs the temple, collecting money for the work, and the workers deal honestly. But the text says he did right "all his days, because Jehoiada the priest instructed him." It hints at a faith that depended on his mentor. We learn in 2 Chronicles that after Jehoiada's death, Joash drifted into idolatry and even killed Jehoiada's son. Borrowed faith is fragile.

In the north, the picture is grim. Syria oppresses Israel, and the kings continue in Jeroboam's sin. Yet there is a flash of mercy: Jehoahaz seeks the LORD, and God gives a deliverer. And the last verses of the section give the reason: God has compassion "because of his covenant with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob." It is grace that keeps Israel, not merit.

Elisha dies, and even in death his bones bring life: a dead man thrown into his tomb touches the bones and revives. God's power is not limited by death.

STEP 5

Connection

Herod would later try to kill the baby of David's line (Matthew 2:16), echoing Athaliah. God protected Jesus, as he protected Joash. Jesus is the true king hidden for a time who will be fully revealed. Revelation 12 shows the dragon trying to devour the child. Romans 11:28-29 says God's calling is irrevocable. The touch of Elisha's bones points to the resurrection life that flows from Christ (1 Corinthians 15:20).

STEP 6

Application

Think about the quiet acts of faithfulness, like Jehosheba's, that God uses to keep his promises. Is there one you can do?

Ask whether your faith depends on another person's influence. How can you make it your own?

Thank God for the covenant that keeps his people, even when they fail.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for hidden acts of courage that preserved his promises.

Ask him to make your faith your own.

Ask him to be gracious to his people.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 50

"Do not fear, for those who are with us are more than those who are with them."

2 KINGS 6:16

DAY 350 · WEEK 50

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 2 Kings 6:16 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Do not fear, for those who are with us are more than those who are with them."

2 KINGS 6:16

REST

Meditation

Elisha says these words to his terrified servant, who has just woken up to find an enemy army surrounding the city. They are among the most comforting words in the Old Testament.

"Do not fear." This is one of the most common commands in the Bible. It is not a shallow instruction to stop feeling afraid. It comes with a reason. The servant had every reason to be afraid. The army was real. The danger was real. But the command rests on something he could not yet see.

"For those who are with us." Elisha says "us." He includes himself and his servant, and he points to a company that has not been introduced. Throughout Scripture, God's people are surrounded by unseen allies. Angels minister to the heirs of salvation (Hebrews 1:14). The host of heaven is real.

“Are more than those who are with them.” It is a statement of comparison. The enemy has numbers, but the people of God have more. It is not a promise that nothing bad will happen, but that, in the end, no enemy can overpower the LORD’s side.

Then Elisha prays, “O LORD, please open his eyes that he may see.” The servant looks again, and the hills are full of horses and chariots of fire. Nothing in the situation changed except the servant’s sight. Faith is not pretending the army isn’t there. It is seeing that there is something greater.

For the Christian, the greater presence is the LORD himself. “If God is for us, who can be against us?” (Romans 8:31). “He who is in you is greater than he who is in the world” (1 John 4:4). When you feel surrounded, ask God to open your eyes.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the healing of Naaman and the greed of Gehazi, the siege of Samaria lifted by four lepers, and Elisha’s vision of the chariots of fire. You read Psalms 44 and 60, the laments of a people who feel rejected by God, and the confidence that vain is the salvation of man. You saw the fall of the house of Ahab at the hand of Jehu, whose zeal was partial, and the near end of David’s line under Athaliah, thwarted by Jehosheba and Jehoiada. And you saw that God keeps his people for the sake of his covenant with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. The week taught that God uses the small and the outcast, that unbelief is costly, and that God preserves his promises through hidden faithfulness.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Naaman nearly missed his healing because the remedy seemed too simple. Where are you tempted to resist grace because it comes in a form you did not expect?

God hid the line of David in the temple for six years. How does that encourage you when God’s promises seem hidden or delayed? How does Christ, the true son of David, fulfill them?

The four lepers said, “This day is a day of good news,” and told others. Who needs to hear good news from you this week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to open your eyes to see those who are with you.

Thank him for his covenant faithfulness.

Rest in Jesus, the true son of David.

DAY 351 · WEEK 51

Psalm 50

I do not rebuke you for sacrifices

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Psalm · 23 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 50. You read this psalm in Unit 6. This time read it as a prophet's sermon, with the books of Kings in mind, and ask what God is saying to a people that went through the motions of religion but lived in injustice.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 50 is a psalm of Asaph, the temple musician. It presents God as a judge who summons his people to court. You first read it in Unit 6 as part of the story of worship. Here, in the age of the prophets, it takes on a different weight. This is exactly the charge that Amos, Hosea, and Micah will bring: sacrifices without obedience, religion without righteousness. Hosea 6:6, the anchor verse of this unit, could be a summary of the psalm.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The Mighty One, God the LORD, speaks and summons the earth from the rising of the sun to its setting" (v. 1).
2. "Out of Zion, the perfection of beauty, God shines forth" (v. 2).
3. "Hear, O my people, and I will speak, O Israel, I will testify against you" (v. 7).
4. "I do not rebuke you for your sacrifices; your burnt offerings are continually before me" (v. 8).
5. "For every beast of the forest is mine, the cattle on a thousand hills" (v. 10).
6. "If I were hungry, I would not tell you, for the world and its fullness are mine" (v. 12).
7. "Offer to God a sacrifice of thanksgiving, and perform your vows to the Most High, and call on me in the day of trouble; I will deliver you, and you shall glorify me" (vv. 14-15).

8 “These things you have done, and I have been silent; you thought that I was one like yourself” (v. 21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The scene is a courtroom, and God is both judge and witness. He summons the whole earth to listen, but the case is against his own people. The covenant people are on trial. This is the language of the prophets: God has a case against Israel.

The surprising part is the charge. God does not say, “You have failed to offer sacrifices.” He says, “I do not rebuke you for your sacrifices.” They have kept the rituals. The problem is that they think the rituals are what God needs. He answers with one of the Bible’s great statements of divine self-sufficiency: “If I were hungry, I would not tell you, for the world and its fullness are mine.” God does not depend on offerings. He owns every animal. To treat sacrifice as a way of feeding or bribing God is to misunderstand who he is.

What he wants is thanksgiving, vows kept, and prayer: “Offer to God a sacrifice of thanksgiving.” The real sacrifice is a heart that gives thanks. The relationship is not transactional. “Call on me in the day of trouble; I will deliver you, and you shall glorify me.” He is the giver, and we are the receivers. Our part is gratitude and trust.

The second half of the psalm turns on the wicked, those who recite God’s statutes but hate discipline. They steal, commit adultery, and slander, while keeping up the appearance of religion. They thought God’s silence meant approval: “You thought that I was one like yourself.” The great danger of religious hypocrisy is the assumption that God is like us, that he overlooks what we overlook.

The psalm ends with a warning and a promise. “Mark this, then, you who forget God, lest I tear you apart.” But “the one who offers thanksgiving as his sacrifice glorifies me; to one who orders his way rightly I will show the salvation of God.”

STEP 5

Connection

Hosea 6:6, which Jesus quotes in Matthew 9:13 and 12:7, says, “I desire steadfast love and not sacrifice.” Hebrews 13:15 says, “Through him then let us continually offer up a sacrifice of praise to God.” Acts 17:24-25 says that God is not served by human hands as though he needed anything. Jesus confronted those who honored God with their lips while their hearts were far from him (Matthew 15:8).

STEP 6

Application

Ask if you ever treat your religious activity as a way of earning God's favor.

Offer a sacrifice of thanksgiving today: name five things you are grateful for.

Examine whether any part of your life is hidden behind religious appearance.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that you can offer him a sacrifice of thanksgiving.

Ask him to keep you from hypocrisy.

Call on him in your day of trouble.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 51

"But let justice roll down like waters, and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream."

AMOS 5:24

DAY 352 · WEEK 51

Psalm 52; Psalm 53

The boastful and the fool

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Psalm · 17 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 52 and Psalm 53. The first is a psalm about a powerful, boastful man who is destroyed. The second is a near twin of Psalm 14, with the fool who says there is no God. Notice the contrast with the green olive tree.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 52 has the title "when Doeg the Edomite, came and told Saul, David has come to the house of Ahimelech." You read that story in Unit 9 (1 Samuel 22). Psalm 53 is a variation of Psalm 14, which you read earlier. Both psalms are by David, and they deal with the arrogance of evil and the fate of those who reject God. Together they fit a unit about a nation that forgot God.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Why do you boast of evil, O mighty man? The steadfast love of God endures all the day" (52:1).
2. "Your tongue plots destruction, like a sharp razor, you worker of deceit" (52:2).
3. "You love evil more than good, and lying more than speaking what is right" (52:3).
4. "But God will break you down forever; he will snatch and tear you from your tent" (52:5).
5. "See the man who would not make God his refuge, but trusted in the abundance of his riches" (52:7).
6. "But I am like a green olive tree in the house of God. I trust in the steadfast love of God forever and ever" (52:8).

7. “The fool says in his heart, There is no God” (53:1).
8. “Oh that salvation for Israel would come out of Zion! When God restores the fortunes of his people, let Jacob rejoice, let Israel be glad” (53:6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 52 addresses Doeg directly, a man who used his power and his tongue to destroy the priests of Nob. David asks the question that exposes all boasting in evil: “Why do you boast?” The wicked man has power, but he does not have God’s steadfast love, which “endures all the day.” Evil has a limited life. The psalm describes a tongue like a razor, a man who loves lies, a man who trusts in riches. And it declares that God will break him down.

The central image is the contrast. The wicked man will be uprooted from his tent and from the land of the living. David, by contrast, is “like a green olive tree in the house of God.” An olive tree is long-lived and fruitful. It is planted in God’s house, in the place of his presence. The wicked man is torn out. The righteous man is rooted. The difference lies in where each puts his trust: in riches, or in “the steadfast love of God forever and ever.”

The psalm ends with thanksgiving. David says he will thank God forever for what he has done, and “wait for your name, for it is good.” He does not take revenge. He waits.

Psalm 53 is almost the same as Psalm 14, with small changes, and the repetition makes a point. The human heart’s tendency to say, “There is no God,” is not an occasional problem. It is universal. “They have all fallen away; together they have become corrupt; there is none who does good, not even one.” The Psalter wants us to hear this twice, so that we do not forget how deep the problem is.

Verse 5 adds a unique line: “There they were in great terror, where there was no terror, for God scatters the bones of him who encamps against you.” God defeats those who oppose his people, sometimes by simply causing fear. And again the psalm ends with the prayer for salvation to come out of Zion.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus is the root and the vine in whom we are planted (John 15:5). Psalm 1 and Jeremiah 17:7-8 echo the image of the tree. Paul quotes Psalm 14 and 53 in Romans 3:10-12 to prove that all are sinners, and he points to Christ as the answer (Romans 3:21-26). 1 Timothy 6:17 warns the rich not to trust in uncertain riches. Salvation did come out of Zion in Jesus (Romans 11:26).

STEP 6

Application

Name something you boast in. Bring it to God and ask for humility.

Thank God that you are planted in his house like an olive tree.

Pray, “Oh that salvation would come out of Zion,” for someone who does not yet know Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to keep you from boasting in evil or trusting in riches.
- Ask him to plant you like an olive tree in his house.
- Confess where you have lived as though there is no God.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 51

“But let justice roll down like waters, and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream.”

AMOS 5:24

DAY 353 · WEEK 51

2 Kings 14:1-15:38

Jeroboam II's prosperity; the northern kingdom's final decades

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 66 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Kings 14:1-15:38. These chapters trace the final decades of the northern kingdom, with Jeroboam II's prosperity and the rapid succession of kings after him. Notice the mixture of God's mercy and judgment.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

In the first half of the 700s BC, Israel and Judah enjoy a period of prosperity and expansion. Jeroboam II of Israel reigns for forty-one years, and Uzziah (Azariah) in Judah for fifty-two. This is the world of Amos and Hosea, whom you will read next. After Jeroboam II, Israel collapses quickly, with six kings in about thirty years, and the Assyrian empire begins to take its land.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Amaziah of Judah does right "yet not like David his father" and wins a victory over Edom but is defeated by Jehoash of Israel (14:3, 7-14).
2. Jeroboam II "did what was evil in the sight of the LORD" (14:24).
3. "He restored the border of Israel from Lebo-hamath as far as the Sea of the Arabah, according to the word of the LORD… which he spoke by his servant Jonah the son of Amittai" (14:25).
4. "For the LORD saw that the affliction of Israel was very bitter… But the LORD had not said that he would blot out the name of Israel from under heaven, so he saved them by the hand of Jeroboam" (14:26-27).
5. Azariah (Uzziah) reigns fifty-two years, and "the LORD touched the king, so that he was a leper to the day of his death" (15:5).

6. Zechariah, Shallum, Menahem, Pekahiah, and Pekah each reign briefly, with murders and coups (15:8-31).
7. Tiglath-pileser, king of Assyria, takes cities and carries people captive (15:19, 29).
8. Jotham of Judah "did what was right… only the high places were not removed" (15:34-35).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jeroboam II's reign is a paradox. By outward measures, it is the best of Israel's northern kings: territorial expansion, wealth, and stability. But the verdict is the same: "He did what was evil." The reason for his success is that God saw the bitter affliction of Israel and had compassion. The prosperity is mercy, not approval. This is a striking reminder that material success is not a sign of God's favor. Israel is flourishing and also rotting. Amos will describe the injustice beneath the prosperity.

Notice the mention of Jonah son of Amittai. The prophet Jonah, whose story you will read in this unit, lived in this time. He delivered a word of hope for Israel's borders. That same man will be sent to preach to Nineveh, Israel's future conqueror.

After Jeroboam II's death, the collapse is quick. The text lists king after king, each murdered by his successor or soon deposed. It is a picture of a nation that has no foundation. Within about thirty years, Assyria will take the land. The speed shows the rottenness of the kingdom.

In Judah, the picture is more stable. Uzziah reigns fifty-two years, and Jotham is faithful. But even the good kings leave the high places. The pattern of partial obedience continues. And Uzziah's leprosy is mentioned briefly here; 2 Chronicles 26 tells us it came when he proudly entered the temple. Pride undoes even the strong.

The chapters prepare the way for the prophets. The nation's outward success covers its decay. The rich oppress the poor. Worship goes on while justice is neglected. The coming words of Amos and Hosea will strip off the surface and show what is underneath.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, "Why do you call me Lord, Lord, and not do what I tell you?" (Luke 6:46). He warned that wealth can blind us (Mark 10:23-25). The mention of Jonah anticipates Jesus' sign of Jonah (Matthew 12:39-41). Revelation 3:17 describes a church that says, "I am rich… I need nothing," and does not know it is wretched. Hebrews 3:13 warns of the deceitfulness of sin.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether your comfort or success has made you less attentive to God.

Think of a time when God showed mercy that you did not deserve. Thank him.

Pray for the leaders of your nation to seek the LORD in their prosperity.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to keep you from mistaking comfort for his approval.
- Ask him to strip away surface religion in you.
- Thank him for seeing the affliction of Israel and showing mercy.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 51

"But let justice roll down like waters, and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream."

AMOS 5:24

DAY 354 · WEEK 51

Amos 1:1-2:16

Judgment on the nations and Israel

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 32 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Amos 1:1-2:16. Amos, a shepherd from Judah, announces God's judgment on the nations around Israel and then, to the shock of his hearers, on Israel itself. Notice the pattern: "For three transgressions… and for four."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Amos prophesied around 760 BC, during the reign of Jeroboam II, "two years before the earthquake." He was not a professional prophet. He was a herdsman and dresser of sycamore figs from Tekoa in Judah, sent north to Israel. His message is one of the sharpest in the Bible: God demands justice, and ritual without righteousness is worthless. The book opens with a series of oracles on the surrounding nations, a pattern that draws Israel in.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The words of Amos, who was among the shepherds of Tekoa" (1:1).
2. "The LORD roars from Zion and utters his voice from Jerusalem" (1:2).
3. "For three transgressions of Damascus, and for four, I will not revoke the punishment" (1:3).
4. The same formula is repeated for Gaza, Tyre, Edom, Ammon, and Moab (1:6-2:3).
5. For Judah: "because they have rejected the law of the LORD, and have not kept his statutes" (2:4).
6. For Israel: "because they sell the righteous for silver, and the needy for a pair of sandals" (2:6).

7. “They trample the head of the poor into the dust of the earth and turn aside the way of the afflicted” (2:7).

8. “Also it was I who brought you up out of the land of Egypt” (2:10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Amos begins like a preacher drawing a crowd. He starts with Israel’s enemies: Damascus, Gaza, Tyre, Edom, Ammon, Moab. His listeners would nod. These nations are guilty of brutality: threshing Gilead with iron sledges, selling whole communities as slaves, tearing open pregnant women, burning the bones of a king. God is a judge of the nations. They are accountable even though they do not have the law of Moses. There is a moral order that all people are expected to honor.

Then Amos turns to Judah, Israel’s southern cousin, and the crowd probably cheers. But the last oracle is the longest, and it is against Israel itself. The formula is the same. But the sins are different. The nations were accused of atrocities in war. Israel is accused of oppressing the poor in times of peace: selling the righteous for silver, trampling the needy, profaning God’s name through sexual exploitation, taking garments in pledge and drinking wine bought with fines. The sins are social and economic. They are everyday injustices committed under cover of respectable religion.

God reminds them of his grace: “It was I who brought you up out of the land of Egypt.” He destroyed the Amorites before them. He raised up prophets and Nazirites. They have responded by making the Nazirites drink wine and silencing the prophets. This is the heart of the charge. Privilege increases responsibility. “You only have I known of all the families of the earth” (3:2). Having received more, they are held to a higher standard.

The consequence is a judgment so complete that “the one who is stout of heart among the mighty shall flee away naked.” No strength will help.

The message of Amos is that God cares about how we treat each other. A faith that has no effect on how we treat the poor is not faith. The same God who roars from Zion is the God who sees the needy sold for a pair of sandals.

STEP 5

Connection

James 1:27 says that pure religion is to visit orphans and widows in their affliction. Jesus said, “Everyone to whom much was given, of him much will be required” (Luke 12:48). Amos speaks to the problem Jesus addressed in Matthew 23:23: neglecting justice, mercy, and

faithfulness while tithing mint and dill. 1 Peter 4:17 says that judgment begins at the household of God. Jesus came to proclaim good news to the poor (Luke 4:18).

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether your faith has any effect on how you treat the poor and the vulnerable.

Examine your business or workplace dealings. Is there any unfairness you tolerate?

Remember that you have been given much. What does that require?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess the injustices you overlook.
- Ask him to let your faith show in how you treat the vulnerable.
- Thank him for bringing his people home.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 51

"But let justice roll down like waters, and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream."

AMOS 5:24

DAY 355 · WEEK 51

Amos 3:1-5:27

The covenant lawsuit; seek the LORD and live

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 54 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Amos 3:1-5:27. These chapters contain three “Hear this word” sermons against Israel, with famous calls to seek the LORD and to let justice roll down. Look for what God says about worship.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Having announced judgment, Amos now explains why. These chapters are made up of three sermons, each beginning with “Hear this word.” They accuse Israel of oppression and complacency, and of a worship that was lavish but empty. In the middle, there are calls to repentance. The language is vivid and sharp, and includes some of the most quoted lines in the prophets.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “You only have I known of all the families of the earth; therefore I will punish you for all your iniquities” (3:2).
2. “Do two walk together, unless they have agreed to meet?” (3:3).
3. “For the Lord GOD does nothing without revealing his secret to his servants the prophets” (3:7).
4. “The lion has roared; who will not fear? The Lord GOD has spoken; who can but prophesy?” (3:8).
5. “Hear this word, you cows of Bashan, who are on the mountain of Samaria, who oppress the poor” (4:1).
6. “Yet you did not return to me, declares the LORD” (4:6, 8, 9, 10, 11).

7. “Seek me and live” (5:4). “Seek good, and not evil, that you may live” (5:14).
8. “I hate, I despise your feasts, and I take no delight in your solemn assemblies… But let justice roll down like waters, and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream” (5:21, 24).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 3 opens with one of the most important principles in the prophets: privilege means accountability. “You only have I known… therefore I will punish you.” To be known by God means to be held to his standards. Israel assumed that being God’s people guaranteed protection. Amos says it guarantees accountability.

The series of rhetorical questions in 3:3-8 establishes cause and effect. Do two walk together unless they agree? Does a lion roar without prey? Does a trap spring without bait? Does disaster come to a city unless the LORD has done it? The point is that nothing happens without a cause, and the prophets speak because God has spoken. Amos is not a free agent. “The Lord GOD has spoken; who can but prophesy?”

Chapter 4 addresses the wealthy women of Samaria, whom Amos calls “cows of Bashan,” who oppress the poor and say to their husbands, “Bring, that we may drink!” It then describes God’s attempts to get Israel’s attention: famine, drought, blight, plague, and defeat. After each, the same refrain: “Yet you did not return to me.” It is one of the saddest lines in the Bible. God had been calling through hardship, and they did not listen. The chapter ends with the warning, “Prepare to meet your God, O Israel!”

Chapter 5 begins with a funeral song for Israel and then offers a way out: “Seek me and live.” The alternative is to seek Bethel, Gilgal, and Beersheba, the places of religious activity. God says, “Do not seek Bethel.” The religion of the nation had become a substitute for the LORD himself.

The center of the section is 5:21-24. God says that he hates their feasts. He will not listen to their songs. He rejects their offerings. What he wants is justice and righteousness: “Let justice roll down like waters.” This does not mean that worship is unimportant. It means that worship divorced from justice is an offense. The two belong together.

STEP 5

Connection

Martin Luther King Jr. and many others have quoted 5:24 as a call to justice. Jesus echoed the prophets: “Not everyone who says to me, Lord, Lord, will enter the kingdom of heaven” (Matthew 7:21). Hebrews 12:25-29 warns against refusing the one who speaks. Revelation

22:17 echoes the call to seek and live. Jesus is the one who "fulfills all righteousness" (Matthew 3:15) and will establish justice (Isaiah 42:1-4).

STEP 6

Application

Ask if your worship and your daily life belong together, or whether there is a gap.

Look back at "Yet you did not return to me." Is God calling you through something right now?

Pray for justice to roll down like waters in your community, and ask how you can take part.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess any gap between your praise and your life.
- Ask him to let you return when he calls you through hardship.
- Ask him to let justice roll in your community.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 51

"But let justice roll down like waters, and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream."

AMOS 5:24

DAY 356 · WEEK 51

Amos 6:1-9:15

Woes; visions; the booth of David rebuilt

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 56 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Amos 6:1-9:15. The book ends with woes against the complacent, five visions of judgment, a confrontation with the priest of Bethel, and a final promise of restoration. Read the closing verses slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The last chapters of Amos strip away the last illusions. The wealthy are comfortable and indifferent. Visions of locusts, fire, a plumb line, and a basket of summer fruit show that the end is near. Then, in the last paragraph, the tone changes completely. God promises to rebuild David's fallen shelter and to restore his people. It is among the great hopeful notes in the prophets.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Woe to those who are at ease in Zion, and to those who feel secure on the mountain of Samaria" (6:1).
2. "Who lie on beds of ivory and stretch themselves out on their couches… but are not grieved over the ruin of Joseph" (6:4-6).
3. Amos sees a plumb line: "Behold, I am setting a plumb line in the midst of my people Israel; I will never again pass by them" (7:7-8).
4. Amaziah the priest tells Amos to go home. Amos says, "I was no prophet, nor a prophet's son, but I was a herdsman and a dresser of sycamore figs. But the LORD took me from following the flock" (7:14-15).
5. A basket of summer fruit: "The end has come upon my people Israel" (8:1-2).

6. “Hear this, you who trample on the needy and bring the poor of the land to an end” (8:4).
7. “Behold, the days are coming… when I will send a famine on the land… of hearing the words of the LORD” (8:11).
8. “In that day I will raise up the booth of David that is fallen and repair its breaches, and raise up its ruins and rebuild it as in the days of old” (9:11).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The woes of chapter 6 describe a comfortable elite: lying on ivory couches, eating lambs from the flock, singing idle songs, drinking wine by the bowl, and anointing themselves with the best oils. “But they are not grieved over the ruin of Joseph.” The problem is not wealth itself but indifference. They are at ease while the nation is falling apart. Complacency is a sin when others suffer.

The visions show God’s patience and its limit. In the first two visions, Amos pleads, and God relents. In the third, a plumb line, there is no more relenting. The plumb line measures a wall. The wall is crooked, and it will be torn down. The standard is God’s own righteousness, and Israel does not match it.

Amaziah, the priest, tries to silence Amos: “Never again prophesy at Bethel, for it is the king’s sanctuary.” The priest’s complaint is revealing. The place of worship has become the king’s property. Amos answers by telling his story. He was a farmer. God took him. He has no choice but to speak. A person called by God cannot be silenced by human authority.

Chapter 8 describes a famine unlike any other, not of bread or water but of hearing the words of the LORD. When God’s word is rejected long enough, it is withdrawn. It is one of the most frightening judgments in the Bible. Yet it also shows how precious the word of God is.

But the book does not end in judgment. The last words are promises: God will raise up the fallen booth of David, restore the fortunes of his people, and plant them in their land, “never again to be uprooted.” The same God who judges also restores. The nations are included: “that they may possess the remnant of Edom and all the nations who are called by my name.” The hope reaches beyond Israel.

STEP 5

Connection

In Acts 15:15-18, James quotes Amos 9:11-12 to show that the inclusion of the Gentiles in the church fulfills God’s promise to rebuild David’s tent. Jesus is the son of David who rebuilds the ruins. Jesus said, “Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that comes from

the mouth of God" (Matthew 4:4). John 12:48 and Hebrews 2:3 warn about neglecting God's word. Luke 16:19-31, the rich man and Lazarus, is a New Testament echo of Amos 6.

STEP 6

Application

Ask if you are at ease while others suffer. What would it look like to be grieved over the ruin of Joseph?

Treasure God's word, and use it, knowing that there can be a famine of hearing it.

Thank God for the promise to rebuild David's fallen tent, fulfilled in Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you have grown complacent.
- Ask him to grieve you over what grieves him.
- Ask him to measure you by his plumb line and make you straight.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 51

"But let justice roll down like waters, and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream."

AMOS 5:24

DAY 357 · WEEK 51

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Amos 5:24 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"But let justice roll down like waters, and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream."

AMOS 5:24

REST

Meditation

This verse is the climax of God's message through Amos. It comes right after God says that he hates their feasts, despises their assemblies, and will not listen to their songs. What he wants in place of all that is this.

"But let justice roll down like waters." The image is of a flood. The Hebrew word for "roll down" suggests a torrent of water in a wadi, pouring through a dry land. It is not a trickle or a drip. The picture is of justice as something abundant, powerful, and unstoppable.

"Justice" is about fairness, the setting right of wrongs. It means that the poor are not trampled, that the weak are protected, that courts are honest, and that the powerful are held accountable.

“And righteousness like an ever-flowing stream.” Righteousness is the character that produces justice: faithfulness to God and to others. The stream is “ever-flowing,” like a perennial spring that does not dry up in summer. Righteousness is not an occasional burst but a constant supply.

In a land where many streams dried up each summer, the image of an ever-flowing stream would have been especially welcome. God wants a justice that does not fail.

How does this verse apply to us? It does not tell us to stop worshiping. It tells us that worship and justice belong together. Our songs and prayers must flow into our workplaces, our families, and our communities.

For the Christian, the source of this stream is Christ. He is the righteous one, who brings justice to the nations (Isaiah 42:1-4). And his Spirit is the living water that flows from within his people (John 7:38). Ask him to make you a channel of justice.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you followed the divided kingdom into the age of the writing prophets. You read the paradox of Jeroboam II’s prosperity, and the collapse of the northern kingdom that came after. You read the psalms of Asaph and of David that warn against empty religion and boasting in evil. And you spent the end of the week with Amos, the shepherd from Tekoa who announced judgment on the nations and then on Israel, because those who had been given much had trampled the poor. You heard God say that he hates their feasts and wants justice to roll down like waters. And you ended with the promise that God will rebuild David’s fallen shelter. The week taught that privilege brings responsibility, that worship without justice is an offense, and that God keeps his promise of restoration.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

God says through Amos that he hates empty worship. What would make your worship more real this week, in your heart and in how you live?

Amos 9:11-12 promises the rebuilding of David’s fallen tent, and Acts 15 says this is fulfilled in Christ and the church. How does this change how you see the church, and the nations who are part of it?

Who are the “poor and needy” in your life, and what does it mean for justice to roll down toward them?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to let justice roll down like waters.
- Thank him for rebuilding David’s fallen tent in Christ.
- Ask him to make you a channel of his justice.

DAY 358 · WEEK 52

Psalm 58

Do you indeed decree what is right?

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 58. It is one of the hardest psalms in the Psalter, a cry for God to judge unjust rulers. Read it as the voice of the oppressed asking for justice, and notice where it ends.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 58 is a Miktam of David set to the tune "Do Not Destroy." It addresses corrupt rulers and judges, the very people Amos condemned for trampling the poor. This is the first of five psalms in this unit about injustice, and the Psalter's prayer for God to act as judge when human courts fail.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Do you indeed decree what is right, O gods? Do you judge the children of man uprightly?" (v. 1).
2. "No, in your hearts you devise wrongs; your hands deal out violence on earth" (v. 2).
3. "The wicked are estranged from the womb; they go astray from birth, speaking lies" (v. 3).
4. "They have venom like the venom of a serpent, like the deaf adder that stops its ear" (vv. 4-5).
5. "O God, break the teeth in their mouths; tear out the fangs of the young lions, O LORD!" (v. 6).
6. "Let them be like the snail that dissolves into slime" (v. 8).
7. "The righteous will rejoice when he sees the vengeance" (v. 10).

8 “Surely there is a reward for the righteous; surely there is a God who judges on earth” (v. 11).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The opening question is directed at those who hold power in the courts, possibly human judges or rulers. They are supposed to “decree what is right,” but their hearts devise wrongs. The scandal is not just that they commit injustice, but that they do it while sitting in judgment. When the institutions designed to protect the weak become tools of the strong, the cry for justice goes up.

The language of the psalm is vivid and violent: teeth broken, fangs torn out, a snail melting. These are not private threats but prayers addressed to God. The psalmist does not take up the sword. He asks God to act. It is important to see this difference. The imprecatory psalms place vengeance in God’s hands. They express honest anger at evil and trust that God will deal with it.

How should Christians read such psalms? We cannot treat them as a license for personal hatred. Jesus taught us to love our enemies and pray for those who persecute us. Yet these psalms still teach us something. They teach that God cares about injustice, that evil is not trivial, and that it is right to want it stopped. They give voice to those who suffer under oppression and who have no other recourse. We can pray them on behalf of the oppressed, and ultimately we can read them in light of the cross, where God’s judgment on evil was carried out in Christ, and at the last day, when it will be completed.

The key line is the last: “Surely there is a God who judges on earth.” It is a statement of faith in the face of apparent injustice. Evil does not have the last word. The psalm teaches us to wait for the God who sees.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “Blessed are those who hunger and thirst for righteousness” (Matthew 5:6), and told of a widow who pleaded with an unjust judge until God’s justice was shown (Luke 18:1-8). Revelation 6:9-10 shows the souls of martyrs crying, “How long?” Paul says, “Never avenge yourselves, but leave it to the wrath of God” (Romans 12:19). Acts 17:31 says God has fixed a day on which he will judge the world in righteousness by a man whom he has appointed.

STEP 6

Application

Pray for someone who is suffering under an unjust system, and ask God to act.

Examine your own use of whatever power you have. Are you using it for justice?

Remember that vengeance belongs to God, and trust him with what you cannot fix.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to break the power of the oppressor and defend the weak.
- Ask him to keep you from taking vengeance yourself.
- Tell him you believe there is a God who judges on earth.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 52

"And I will betroth you to me forever. I will betroth you to me in righteousness and in justice, in steadfast love and in mercy."

HOSEA 2:19

DAY 359 · WEEK 52

Psalm 82

God has taken his place in the divine council

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Psalm · 8 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 82. It is a short psalm in which God holds court over the “gods” and condemns them for judging unjustly. Read it slowly, and notice that Jesus quotes it.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 82 is a psalm of Asaph. It describes God taking his place in the divine council and passing judgment on those called “gods.” Interpreters differ on who these are: human judges and rulers, or heavenly beings who held authority over the nations. Either way, the psalm’s point is clear: all who hold power answer to the LORD. It pairs with Psalm 58 as a statement of God’s concern for the weak.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “God has taken his place in the divine council; in the midst of the gods he holds judgment” (v. 1).
2. “How long will you judge unjustly and show partiality to the wicked?” (v. 2).
3. “Give justice to the weak and the fatherless; maintain the right of the afflicted and the destitute” (v. 3).
4. “Rescue the weak and the needy; deliver them from the hand of the wicked” (v. 4).
5. “They have neither knowledge nor understanding, they walk about in darkness; all the foundations of the earth are shaken” (v. 5).
6. “I said, You are gods, sons of the Most High, all of you” (v. 6).
7. “Nevertheless, like men you shall die, and fall like any prince” (v. 7).
8. “Arise, O God, judge the earth! For you shall inherit all the nations!” (v. 8).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens in a courtroom in heaven. God is the judge, and those who stand before him are called "gods." The word elohim in the Hebrew can refer to God, to angels, or to human authorities who act in God's name. Some read the "gods" as the spiritual powers behind the nations, and others as human judges, called gods because they exercise God-given authority. In either case, the meaning of the psalm is the same. Those entrusted with rule are accountable to the one who rules over all.

God's charge is about the poor. He does not accuse them of false doctrine. He accuses them of partiality and injustice. The tests of a ruler are: do the weak receive justice? Are the fatherless and the afflicted protected? God lists four things: give justice, maintain rights, rescue, and deliver. These are the duties of anyone with power.

Verse 5 describes the consequence. When rulers fail, "all the foundations of the earth are shaken." Injustice at the top destabilizes everything. A society that does not protect its weakest members loses its footing.

Verse 6 and 7 are the heart of the psalm. God says that he appointed them: "You are gods, sons of the Most High." They have a high calling. But they will die like any man. The honor of their office does not make them immortal. The psalm humbles all who hold power.

The final verse is a prayer: "Arise, O God, judge the earth!" When human rulers fail, the psalmist turns to God. He is the only perfectly just ruler, and he will inherit all the nations.

When Jesus was accused of blasphemy for calling himself the Son of God, he quoted verse 6 (John 10:34-36). If Scripture could call mere human rulers "gods" because the word of God came to them, how much more could the one whom the Father consecrated and sent into the world claim to be God's Son?

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus quotes this psalm in John 10:34-36. He is the true judge, to whom the Father has given all judgment (John 5:22). Colossians 2:15 says that Christ disarmed the rulers and authorities. 1 Corinthians 15:24-25 says he must reign until he has put all his enemies under his feet. The psalm's last line is fulfilled in Revelation 11:15: "The kingdom of the world has become the kingdom of our Lord and of his Christ."

STEP 6

Application

If you have authority at work, in your family, or in your church, ask how you treat the weak.

Pray for rulers to remember they will die, and that they answer to God.

Pray “Arise, O God, judge the earth” for a specific situation of injustice.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Pray for those in authority to give justice to the weak.
- Ask him to keep you from abusing any power you have.
- Praise him as judge of all the earth.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 52

“And I will betroth you to me forever. I will betroth you to me in righteousness and in justice, in steadfast love and in mercy.”

HOSEA 2:19

DAY 360 · WEEK 52

Psalm 94

O LORD, God of vengeance, the cry for justice

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Psalm · 23 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 94. It is a prayer to the God of vengeance for the oppressed. Notice how it moves from complaint to teaching, and from anxiety to the comfort of God's steadfast love.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 94 has no title. It is a communal and personal lament, and it is also a wisdom psalm, with a section that instructs the arrogant. The enemies are oppressors within the covenant community, who "kill the widow and the sojourner, and murder the fatherless." It is the third of the psalms of justice in this unit.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "O LORD, God of vengeance, O God of vengeance, shine forth!" (v. 1).
2. "Rise up, O judge of the earth; repay to the proud what they deserve!" (v. 2).
3. "How long shall the wicked, O LORD, how long shall the wicked exult?" (v. 3).
4. "They kill the widow and the sojourner, and murder the fatherless; and they say, The LORD does not see" (vv. 6-7).
5. "He who planted the ear, does he not hear? He who formed the eye, does he not see?" (v. 9).
6. "Blessed is the man whom you discipline, O LORD, and whom you teach out of your law" (v. 12).
7. "When I thought, My foot slips, your steadfast love, O LORD, held me up" (v. 18).
8. "When the cares of my heart are many, your consolations cheer my soul" (v. 19).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a bold double address: "O God of vengeance." The word "vengeance" here means just retribution, the action of a judge who puts things right. It is not petty revenge. The psalmist asks God to "shine forth," to appear as a judge and deal with the proud.

The complaint is fully honest. The wicked exult. They boast. They crush God's people. And they say, "The LORD does not see." This is the arrogance of those who think no one is watching. The psalmist answers them with a rhetorical question: "He who planted the ear, does he not hear? He who formed the eye, does he not see?" It is the answer of logic. The Creator of ears and eyes must himself hear and see. God's knowledge is not less than ours but infinitely greater.

Then the psalm shifts to a more personal note. "Blessed is the man whom you discipline, O LORD, and whom you teach out of your law, to give him rest from days of trouble." A person who is taught by God finds rest even in times of trouble. This is a different way to see suffering: as a place of instruction. The psalmist knows that the LORD will not forsake his people.

The center of the psalm's comfort is verses 18 and 19. "When I thought, My foot slips, your steadfast love held me up." The psalmist's footing was failing. And God's covenant love caught him. And when the cares of his heart multiplied, God's consolations cheered his soul. The word "cares" can mean also "anxious thoughts." When anxieties pile up, God's comfort is greater.

The psalm ends in confidence: "The LORD has become my stronghold, and my God the rock of my refuge. He will bring back on them their iniquity." God will deal with the wicked in his own time. Meanwhile, he is a refuge.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said that nothing is hidden that will not be made known (Luke 12:2-3), and that the Father sees in secret (Matthew 6:4). Hebrews 12:5-11 draws on this teaching about discipline. Philippians 4:6-7 speaks of casting anxieties on God. 1 Peter 5:7 says, "Casting all your anxieties on him, because he cares for you." 2 Corinthians 1:3-5 describes God as the Father of mercies and God of all comfort.

STEP 6

Application

When anxious thoughts multiply, pray verse 19 and let God's consolations cheer you.

Ask whether you ever act as if God does not see. Bring any hidden thing to him.

Thank God that when your foot slips, his steadfast love holds you up.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to shine forth against injustice.
- Thank him that when your foot slips he holds you.
- Ask him to console you when cares are many.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 52

"And I will betroth you to me forever. I will betroth you to me in righteousness and in justice, in steadfast love and in mercy."

HOSEA 2:19

DAY 361 · WEEK 52

Psalm 109

Be not silent, O God of my praise, the cry against the wicked

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Psalm · 31 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 109. This is the most severe of the imprecatory psalms. Read it carefully, ask whose voice is speaking in the middle section, and watch how the psalm ends.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 109 is a psalm of David, and the psalmist is the target of slander and false accusation. He prays against a particular enemy with one of the longest curses in the Bible. Interpreters differ on whether verses 6 to 19 are the psalmist's curse or a quotation of what his enemies say about him. Whichever reading is taken, the psalm shows what to do with the deepest anger: bring it to God.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Be not silent, O God of my praise!" (v. 1).
2. "For wicked and deceitful mouths are opened against me, speaking against me with lying tongues" (v. 2).
3. "In return for my love they accuse me, but I give myself to prayer" (v. 4).
4. "So they reward me evil for good, and hatred for my love" (v. 5).
5. The long curse: "May his days be few; may another take his office" (vv. 6-19).
6. "But you, O GOD my Lord, deal on my behalf for your name's sake; because your steadfast love is good, deliver me!" (v. 21).
7. "For I am poor and needy, and my heart is stricken within me" (v. 22).
8. "For he stands at the right hand of the needy, to save him from those who condemn his soul to death" (v. 31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with a plea for God not to be silent. The psalmist has been slandered. The attack is cruel because it is unprovoked: “In return for my love they accuse me.” His response is not to retaliate but to pray: “I give myself to prayer.” The Hebrew is literally, “I am prayer.” His whole life has become an act of prayer in the face of attack.

The long section in verses 6 to 19 is severe. The language is of a legal curse on a specific person: may he be condemned, may his prayer be counted as sin, may his children be fatherless. Many readers find this unsettling, and it is. Some scholars suggest that verses 6 to 19 are a quotation of the accusers’ words against the psalmist, which he then answers beginning in verse 21. In that reading, he is quoting their curses and handing them to God. Others understand the section as his own prayer against an unrepentant persecutor. In either case, the psalm shows what the Bible allows: raw honesty before God about injustice.

Whatever one concludes, the key move is what the psalmist does next. He does not stop with the curse. He turns to God: “But you, O GOD my Lord, deal on my behalf for your name’s sake.” He appeals not to his own righteousness but to God’s name and steadfast love. “Because your steadfast love is good, deliver me!” He admits that he is “poor and needy.” He is desperate.

The psalm ends with confidence and praise: “With my mouth I will give great thanks to the LORD.” He will praise in the midst of the throng. The reason is verse 31: God “stands at the right hand of the needy.” Where an accuser stands at the right hand of the wicked (v. 6), God stands at the right hand of the poor, as an advocate.

The psalm shows us that we may bring even our darkest feelings to God, and that he will turn them toward trust.

STEP 5

Connection

Peter quotes verse 8 in Acts 1:20 in connection with Judas, and the early church read this psalm as a picture of the suffering of Christ. Jesus was repaid with hatred for his love (John 15:25). On the cross he prayed for his enemies (Luke 23:34). He is the one who stands at the right hand of God as our advocate (Acts 7:56; 1 John 2:1). Romans 12:14 says, “Bless those who persecute you; bless and do not curse.”

STEP 6

Application

If you have a bitter feeling against someone, bring it to God in prayer, not into action.

Remember that God stands at the right hand of the needy, as your advocate.

Pray for an enemy by name, for their repentance and their good.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Bring God the accusations or hurts you carry, and give yourself to prayer.

Ask him to deal for you for his name's sake.

Pray for the one who wronged you, as Jesus did.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 52

"And I will betroth you to me forever. I will betroth you to me in righteousness and in justice, in steadfast love and in mercy."

HOSEA 2:19

DAY 362 · WEEK 52

Psalm 140; Psalm 142

Deliver me from evil men; with my voice I cry to the LORD

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Psalm · 20 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 140 and Psalm 142. The first asks God to protect from violent and slanderous men. The second is David's prayer in the cave. Notice how each ends with a statement of confidence.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 140 is a psalm of David asking for deliverance from violent men. Psalm 142 is a Maskil of David, when he was in the cave, which refers to his flight from Saul in 1 Samuel 22 or 24. They conclude this series of psalms on injustice. In the first, evil men plot. In the second, the psalmist cries out from a place where no one cares for him.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Deliver me, O LORD, from evil men; preserve me from violent men" (140:1).
2. "They make their tongue sharp as a serpent's, and under their lips is the venom of asps" (140:3).
3. "I say to the LORD, You are my God; give ear to the voice of my pleas for mercy, O LORD!" (140:6).
4. "O LORD, my Lord, the strength of my salvation, you have covered my head in the day of battle" (140:7).
5. "I know that the LORD will maintain the cause of the afflicted, and will execute justice for the needy" (140:12).
6. "With my voice I cry out to the LORD; with my voice I plead for mercy to the LORD" (142:1).

7. “When my spirit faints within me, you know my way!” (142:3).
8. “I cry to you, O LORD; I say, You are my refuge, my portion in the land of the living” (142:5).

STEP 4

Interpretation

In Psalm 140, the danger is both physical and verbal. The enemies “plan evil things in their heart and stir up wars continually.” Their words are sharp as a snake’s. The psalmist feels hunted: they have hidden a trap for him and spread a net. His response is not to fight but to pray. “I say to the LORD, You are my God.” It is the simplest declaration of faith. In the middle of danger, he claims his relationship with the LORD.

A phrase deserves attention: “You have covered my head in the day of battle.” In war, the head is the most vulnerable. God has been his helmet. It is a vivid expression of divine protection. And at the end, the psalmist declares confidence: “I know that the LORD will maintain the cause of the afflicted.” He knows. His faith rests not on seeing but on God’s character.

Psalm 142 brings us to the cave. David is alone, hunted, and desperate. He prays aloud: “With my voice I cry out.” There is no pretense. He pours out his complaint and tells his trouble before God. The line that stands out is verse 4: “Look to the right and see: there is none who takes notice of me; no refuge remains to me; no one cares for my soul.” It is the cry of utter loneliness. But the next verse is the turn: “I cry to you, O LORD; I say, You are my refuge, my portion in the land of the living.”

When no human refuge remains, the psalmist declares that God is his refuge. “You are my portion,” he says, as the Levites who had no land received the LORD as their inheritance. Everything has been stripped from David, and he discovers that God is enough.

The psalm ends with a hope: “Bring me out of prison, that I may give thanks to your name! The righteous will surround me, for you will deal bountifully with me.” The cave will not be the last word. He will again be among God’s people.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus, in Gethsemane and on the cross, was alone, forsaken by his disciples (Matthew 26:56). Yet he said, “I am not alone, for the Father is with me” (John 16:32). Hebrews 13:5-6 promises, “I will never leave you nor forsake you,” so we can say, “The Lord is my helper.” Ephesians 6:17 says to take the helmet of salvation. 2 Timothy 4:16-17 echoes Paul’s abandonment and the Lord’s strengthening.

STEP 6

Application

If you feel that no one cares for your soul, pray Psalm 142:5 aloud: “You are my refuge, my portion.”

Pray verse 140:7 and ask God to cover your head in the day of battle.

Look for someone who is alone and take notice of them.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God you are his and he is yours.
- Ask him to deliver you from evil and to be your refuge.
- Tell him what faints within you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 52

“And I will betroth you to me forever. I will betroth you to me in righteousness and in justice, in steadfast love and in mercy.”

HOSEA 2:19

DAY 363 · WEEK 52

Hosea 1:1-3:5

Hosea and Gomer; the broken marriage as Israel's story

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 30 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Hosea 1:1-3:5. Hosea is told to marry a woman who will be unfaithful, and his marriage becomes a picture of God and Israel. This is one of the most moving stories in the Bible. Read the whole of chapter 2, and ask what God is feeling.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Hosea prophesied in the northern kingdom in the decades before its fall, from the time of Jeroboam II to about 722 BC. He was a contemporary of Amos, but the tone of his message is different. Amos spoke of justice, and Hosea speaks of love. His own marriage becomes a living sermon. God tells him to marry a woman who will be unfaithful, so that he can feel something of what God feels over Israel's unfaithfulness.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Go, take to yourself a wife of whoredom and have children of whoredom, for the land commits great whoredom by forsaking the LORD" (1:2).
2. The children are named Jezreel, No Mercy (Lo-ruhamah), and Not My People (Lo-ammi) (1:4-9).
3. "Yet the number of the children of Israel shall be like the sand of the sea... In the place where it was said to them, You are not my people, it shall be said to them, Children of the living God" (1:10).
4. "She did not know that it was I who gave her the grain, the wine, and the oil" (2:8).
5. "Therefore, behold, I will allure her, and bring her into the wilderness, and speak tenderly to her" (2:14).

6. “And I will betroth you to me forever. I will betroth you to me in righteousness and in justice, in steadfast love and in mercy” (2:19).

7. “And I will say to Not My People, You are my people; and he shall say, You are my God” (2:23).

8. “Go again, love a woman who is loved by another man and is an adulteress, even as the LORD loves the children of Israel” (3:1).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The story of Hosea is shocking on purpose. God tells his prophet to marry Gomer, and the text implies that she will be unfaithful. Their children are given names that preach: Jezreel, a reminder of Jehu’s bloodshed; No Mercy; and Not My People. The names are a message of judgment. A nation that broke covenant will lose the privileges of the covenant.

Chapter 2 is a courtroom drama that turns into a love song. First, God speaks as a wronged husband. Israel has run after her lovers, the Baals, thinking they were the ones who gave her grain, wine, and oil. “She did not know that it was I who gave her the grain.” Idolatry is ingratitude. It credits the gifts to the wrong giver. God says he will strip away what she was relying on, so that she will see.

Then, in verse 14, the tone changes completely. “Therefore, behold, I will allure her.” After the judgment, God does not abandon her. He takes her to the wilderness, the place of their first love, and “speaks tenderly to her.” The word means to speak to the heart. And he promises to make the Valley of Achor, the valley of trouble, “a door of hope.” He promises a new marriage: “I will betroth you to me forever.” The phrase is repeated three times. And it comes with a list of the gifts of the new covenant: righteousness, justice, steadfast love, mercy, and faithfulness. The result: “You shall know the LORD.”

The names are reversed. “I will say to Not My People, You are my people.” Mercy is given to those who had no mercy.

Chapter 3 is the costly part of the story. Hosea is told to buy back his wife from slavery or prostitution, for fifteen shekels of silver and some barley. This is the picture of redemption. God loves the unlovable and pays the price to bring her home. And the chapter ends by looking forward to the day when Israel will seek the LORD and “David their king.”

STEP 5

Connection

Paul quotes Hosea 1:10 and 2:23 in Romans 9:25-26 and Peter quotes them in 1 Peter 2:10 to describe the church: “Once you were not a people, but now you are God’s people; once you had not received mercy, but now you have received mercy.” Hosea’s redemption of Gomer is a picture of Christ’s redeeming his bride (Ephesians 5:25-27; 1 Corinthians 6:20). Jesus said, “I came not to call the righteous, but sinners” (Mark 2:17).

STEP 6

Application

Reflect on being “Not My People” and now “My People.” What does mercy mean to you?

Ask God to speak tenderly to you in your wilderness.

Think about whom you are tempted to give up on. How does Hosea’s love challenge you?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for loving you when you were not his people.
- Thank him for buying you back.
- Ask him to allure you and speak tenderly to you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 52

“And I will betroth you to me forever. I will betroth you to me in righteousness and in justice, in steadfast love and in mercy.”

HOSEA 2:19

DAY 364 · WEEK 52

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Hosea 2:19 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"And I will betroth you to me forever. I will betroth you to me in righteousness and in justice, in steadfast love and in mercy."

HOSEA 2:19

REST

Meditation

This promise is spoken to an unfaithful wife. It is the Bible's most tender picture of what God intends for his people.

"And I will betroth you to me forever." To betroth is to make a solemn promise of marriage. It is the beginning of a covenant. Israel had broken the covenant again and again, but God does not take back his love. The word "forever" stands out. This is not a temporary arrangement that could be broken again. It is a permanent commitment.

The word "betroth" is repeated three times in verses 19 and 20, as if God cannot say it enough. A man who had been wronged has every reason to refuse. Yet he says it again and again.

“In righteousness and in justice.” These are the foundation of the new marriage. This is not sentimental love that ignores wrong. It is a love that is built on what is right. In the new covenant, justice is satisfied, not set aside. The cross is where righteousness and love meet.

“In steadfast love and in mercy.” These are the heart of the covenant. Steadfast love is covenant loyalty, the faithful love that does not let go. Mercy is compassion toward the needy. God promises to give them to his people, not because of their record but because of who he is.

The verse that follows adds, “And you shall know the LORD.” The goal of the marriage is a relationship of knowledge. The people will know their husband.

For the Christian, this promise is realized in Christ. He is the bridegroom, and the church is his bride. He has paid the price. “I will betroth you to me forever” is a promise for you, if you are in him. Say it as a statement of what God has done.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the psalms of injustice: Psalms 58, 82, 94, 109, 140, and 142, the cries of those who suffer under corrupt power, with the confidence that there is a God who judges on earth. You saw that Jesus quoted Psalm 82 and that God stands at the right hand of the needy. And you began the book of Hosea, the prophet whose marriage to an unfaithful woman became a picture of God’s love for Israel. You read about the children with names like No Mercy and Not My People, and about the God who allures his wayward bride into the wilderness and speaks tenderly to her. You saw Hosea buy back Gomer, and you heard the promise: I will betroth you to me forever. The week taught that God hears the cry of the oppressed, and that his love is stronger than his people’s unfaithfulness.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

The psalms of this week take honest, angry prayers to God. What injustice or hurt do you need to bring to him in prayer rather than in action?

Hosea buys back his unfaithful wife, a picture of Christ redeeming his people. What does it mean to you that you were bought at a price?

God says he will “speak tenderly” to Israel in the wilderness. Where do you need to hear his tenderness right now?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for betrothing you to himself forever.

Thank him for buying you back at the cost of his Son.

Ask him to speak tenderly to you this Sabbath.

DAY 365 · WEEK 53

Hosea 4:1-7:16

“I desire steadfast love not sacrifice”

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 60 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Hosea 4:1-7:16. The prophet now brings God’s charges against Israel: no knowledge of God, empty worship, and a heart that is like a morning cloud. These chapters include the unit’s anchor verse, Hosea 6:6. Read it in its setting.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The second part of Hosea consists of a series of oracles that mix accusation and pleading. God has a lawsuit against Israel. The charge is unfaithfulness to the covenant: idolatry, injustice, and a lack of the knowledge of God. The priests and the political leaders are especially blamed. The section includes a beautiful invitation to return and a sharp reply that shows how shallow Israel’s repentance was.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Hear the word of the LORD, O children of Israel, for the LORD has a controversy with the inhabitants of the land. There is no faithfulness or steadfast love, and no knowledge of God in the land” (4:1).
2. “My people are destroyed for lack of knowledge; because you have rejected knowledge, I reject you from being a priest to me” (4:6).
3. “A spirit of whoredom has led them astray, and they have left their God to play the whore” (4:12).
4. “Ephraim is joined to idols; leave him alone” (4:17).
5. “Come, let us return to the LORD; for he has torn us, that he may heal us; he has struck us down, and he will bind us up” (6:1).

6. “Let us know; let us press on to know the LORD; his going out is sure as the dawn” (6:3).
7. “What shall I do with you, O Ephraim? What shall I do with you, O Judah? Your love is like a morning cloud, like the dew that goes early away” (6:4).
8. “For I desire steadfast love and not sacrifice, the knowledge of God rather than burnt offerings” (6:6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The lawsuit begins with a three-part diagnosis: no faithfulness, no steadfast love, and no knowledge of God. The first two are relational. The third is the root. The people had stopped knowing God. They no longer understood who he was or what he wanted. As a result, the society fell apart: swearing, lying, murder, stealing, adultery. “My people are destroyed for lack of knowledge.” The knowledge in view is not just information but a relationship, the knowledge of a husband and wife. It is the loss of intimacy with God.

Priests are especially blamed. They fed on the sin of the people, wanting them to sin so that the offerings would increase. A priesthood that profits from the sins of the people has lost its purpose.

Chapter 6 opens with what sounds like a model of repentance: “Come, let us return to the LORD.” The words are beautiful. They acknowledge that God has torn and will heal, that he will revive them after two days. But God’s response is devastating: “What shall I do with you?” He knows how shallow it is. “Your love is like a morning cloud, like the dew that goes early away.” Their repentance burns off with the morning sun. It is a feeling, not a commitment.

Then comes the unit’s anchor verse. “For I desire steadfast love and not sacrifice, the knowledge of God rather than burnt offerings.” The people thought that offering sacrifices would fix the relationship. God says that what he wants is a heart that loves and knows him. It does not make sacrifice meaningless, since God himself commanded it. It means that sacrifice without love is empty.

Chapter 7 continues with a series of pictures of Israel’s folly: a cake that is burned on one side and raw on the other, a silly dove flitting between Egypt and Assyria. Israel is half-baked, unstable, and turning to the wrong help. “They do not cry to me from the heart.”

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus quotes Hosea 6:6 twice: when defending his eating with sinners (Matthew 9:13) and when defending his disciples on the Sabbath (Matthew 12:7). He told the Pharisees, “Go and learn what this means.” John 17:3 says, “This is eternal life, that they know you the only true God.” Paul longs to know Christ (Philippians 3:10). Hebrews 13:15-16 says that the sacrifices pleasing to God are praise and doing good.

STEP 6

Application

Take Hosea 6:6 with you, and let it search you.

Ask whether your repentance has been like a morning cloud. What would a lasting change look like?

Make time to know God, not just to do things for him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God you desire to know him, and ask him to keep your love from fading like a morning cloud.
- Confess where religious activity has replaced your heart.
- Ask him to teach you to love steadfastly.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 53

“But I with the voice of thanksgiving will sacrifice to you; what I have vowed I will pay. Salvation belongs to the LORD!”

JONAH 2:9

DAY 366 · WEEK 53

Hosea 8:1-11:12

Israel's persistent adultery; "How can I give you up?"

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 56 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Hosea 8:1-11:12. Chapters 8 to 10 describe Israel's idolatry and coming judgment. Chapter 11 is one of the most emotionally powerful chapters in the prophets: God's heart breaks over his people. Read chapter 11 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

These chapters continue the lawsuit against Israel. The people have made kings without God's approval, set up idols, and made alliances with Assyria. They will reap what they sow. But in chapter 11, the language changes from a courtroom to a family. God is a father who taught his child to walk, and the child went away. The chapter is among the clearest statements in the Old Testament of God's compassionate heart.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "For they sow the wind, and they shall reap the whirlwind" (8:7).
2. "For Israel has forgotten his Maker and built palaces" (8:14).
3. "Sow for yourselves righteousness; reap steadfast love; break up your fallow ground, for it is time to seek the LORD, that he may come and rain righteousness upon you" (10:12).
4. "You have plowed iniquity; you have reaped injustice; you have eaten the fruit of lies" (10:13).
5. "When Israel was a child, I loved him, and out of Egypt I called my son" (11:1).
6. "Yet it was I who taught Ephraim to walk; I took them up by their arms, but they did not know that I healed them" (11:3).
7. "I led them with cords of kindness, with the bands of love" (11:4).

8 “How can I give you up, O Ephraim? How can I hand you over, O Israel?... My heart recoils within me; my compassion grows warm and tender” (11:8).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The sayings of chapters 8 to 10 contain some of the most quoted lines in Hosea. “They sow the wind, and they shall reap the whirlwind.” Sin has consequences that exceed what we expect. A small seed of rebellion grows into a storm. “Israel has forgotten his Maker and built palaces.” The root of the problem is forgetting God, and the result is a grand life built without him.

Chapter 10 contains a call that is both an accusation and an invitation: “Break up your fallow ground.” Fallow ground is hard, unplowed soil. The people’s hearts have become hard. God invites them to cultivate them, to sow righteousness and reap steadfast love, to seek the LORD until he rains righteousness on them. Even in judgment, there is an open door.

Chapter 11 is the emotional center of the book. God remembers when Israel was a child. “Out of Egypt I called my son.” He taught him to walk, held him by the arms, healed him, and led him with cords of kindness. The picture of a parent teaching a toddler to take steps is touching. But the more they were called, the more they went away. They sacrificed to Baals and offered incense to idols. Now they will go into exile.

Then God asks, “How can I give you up, O Ephraim?” The sentence is a cry from the heart. Admah and Zeboiim were cities destroyed along with Sodom. God says, “How can I make you like Admah?” His heart recoils. “My compassion grows warm and tender.” God does not simply carry out judgment. He struggles with it. The text shows his holiness and his love in tension, and love wins: “I will not execute my burning anger... for I am God and not a man, the Holy One in your midst.”

This is a deep statement of who God is. His love is not like human love, which gives up when it is wounded. He is God, and he will not give up.

STEP 5

Connection

Matthew 2:15 quotes Hosea 11:1 and applies it to Jesus, who was called out of Egypt as God’s true Son, the faithful Israel. Jesus wept over Jerusalem as a hen gathering her chicks (Matthew 23:37). Jesus is the one in whom God’s compassion took flesh. Luke 15:20 shows the father running to the prodigal son. 1 John 4:10 says, “In this is love, not that we have loved God but that he loved us.”

STEP 6

Application

Ask where you have “fallow ground,” areas where your heart has hardened. Begin to break it up.

Take comfort from the image of God teaching you to walk. Where has he held you by the arms without your noticing?

Reflect on “How can I give you up?” and let it settle in your heart.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess what you have sown and fear to reap.
- Ask him to break up the fallow ground of your heart.
- Thank him for teaching you to walk and leading you with cords of kindness.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 53

“But I with the voice of thanksgiving will sacrifice to you; what I have vowed I will pay. Salvation belongs to the LORD!”

JONAH 2:9

DAY 367 · WEEK 53

Hosea 12:1-14:9

God's love persists; the promise of return

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 41 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Hosea 12:1-14:9. Hosea ends with a review of Jacob's story, a final warning, and one of the most beautiful calls to repentance in the Bible. Read chapter 14 slowly, and ask what God promises.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The last section of Hosea draws on Israel's history, going back to their ancestor Jacob, and shows how the nation has repeated his deceit. It then moves to a final accusation and the announcement of judgment. But the book does not end in judgment. In chapter 14 God offers words to say, a promise of healing, and a vision of flourishing. It is among the great gospel passages of the Old Testament.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "In the womb he took his brother by the heel, and in his manhood he strove with God" (12:3).
2. "So you, by the help of your God, return, hold fast to love and justice, and wait continually for your God" (12:6).
3. "I am the LORD your God from the land of Egypt; you know no God but me, and besides me there is no savior" (13:4).
4. "I shall ransom them from the power of Sheol; I shall redeem them from Death. O Death, where are your plagues? O Sheol, where is your sting?" (13:14).
5. "Return, O Israel, to the LORD your God, for you have stumbled because of your iniquity" (14:1).

6. “Take with you words and return to the LORD; say to him, Take away all iniquity; accept what is good” (14:2).

7. “I will heal their apostasy; I will love them freely, for my anger has turned from them” (14:4).

8. “I will be like the dew to Israel; he shall blossom like the lily; he shall take root like the trees of Lebanon” (14:5).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Hosea revisits the story of Jacob, the schemer who grasped his brother’s heel and wrestled with God. Jacob is a mirror for Israel: a deceiver, a striver. But Jacob also “wept and sought his favor” and met God at Bethel. The point is that the same God who found Jacob can find Israel. “So you, by the help of your God, return.” Repentance is possible, with God’s help.

Chapter 13 contains a reminder that God alone is the Savior. “You know no God but me, and besides me there is no savior.” This is a central claim of the Bible. And in the middle of the chapter, there is an astonishing promise: “I shall ransom them from the power of Sheol; I shall redeem them from Death.” Paul quotes this in 1 Corinthians 15:55, as a proclamation of the resurrection. Even in a chapter about judgment, God declares that he will defeat death.

Chapter 14 is the climax. It begins with a call: “Return, O Israel.” Then God gives them words to use. “Take with you words.” Repentance should not be left to chance. God provides the language: take away all iniquity, accept what is good, we will no more say to the work of our hands, “Our God.” Israel is to confess, to turn from false hopes, to trust in God alone. “In you the orphan finds mercy.”

God’s reply is stunning. “I will heal their apostasy; I will love them freely.” The word “freely” means without any cost, without conditions. This is grace. God’s anger has turned away. The language of the garden follows: dew, lily, roots, branches like an olive tree, fragrance like Lebanon, grain, vine. It is a picture of life and fruitfulness. The barren, unfaithful nation will flourish. “From me comes your fruit.”

The book ends with a wisdom question: “Whoever is wise, let him understand these things.” The ways of the LORD are right, and the righteous walk in them, but transgressors stumble. The hearer must choose.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul quotes Hosea 13:14 in 1 Corinthians 15:55: “O death, where is your victory? O death, where is your sting?” Christ’s resurrection fulfills it. Romans 3:24 says we are “justified by his grace as a gift,” echoing “I will love them freely.” Jesus said, “I am the vine; you are the branches… apart from me you can do nothing” (John 15:5). Hebrews 13:15 calls us to offer a sacrifice of praise, “the fruit of lips that acknowledge his name,” echoing Hosea 14:2.

STEP 6

Application

Use Hosea 14:2 as a prayer of repentance today. Say the words God provides.

Receive the promise: “I will love them freely.” What would change if you believed it?

Ask where you are trusting in Assyria, horses, or the work of your hands rather than in the LORD.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to take away all iniquity and accept what is good in you.
- Tell him you return to him, and heal your apostasy.
- Ask him to be like the dew to you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 53

“But I with the voice of thanksgiving will sacrifice to you; what I have vowed I will pay. Salvation belongs to the LORD!”

JONAH 2:9

DAY 368 · WEEK 53

Psalm 74

Why do you cast us off forever?

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Psalm · 23 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 74. It is a communal lament over the destruction of the sanctuary. Notice how the psalmist reasons with God, recalling his past deeds and appealing to his covenant.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 74 is a Maskil of Asaph. It was likely written after the destruction of the temple by the Babylonians, though the destruction of the northern sanctuaries by the Assyrians also fits. It is placed here as the Psalter's response to the fall of the divided kingdoms. The congregation is bewildered, as Hosea predicted, and asks God how long and why.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "O God, why do you cast us off forever? Why does your anger smoke against the sheep of your pasture?" (v. 1).
2. "Remember your congregation, which you have purchased of old, which you have redeemed to be the tribe of your heritage" (v. 2).
3. "Your foes have roared in the midst of your meeting place; they set up their own signs for signs" (v. 4).
4. "They said to themselves, We will utterly subdue them; they burned all the meeting places of God in the land" (v. 8).
5. "We do not see our signs; there is no longer any prophet, and there is none among us who knows how long" (v. 9).
6. "Yet God my King is from of old, working salvation in the midst of the earth" (v. 12).

7. “Yours is the day, yours also the night; you have established the heavenly lights and the sun” (v. 16).

8. “Have regard for the covenant… Arise, O God, defend your cause” (vv. 20, 22).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with the question, “Why?” It does not hold back. God has cast off his people, and his anger smokes. The picture of “the sheep of your pasture” reminds us that God is a shepherd. How can a shepherd be angry at his own sheep? The psalmist asks God to look at what has happened. He asks him to walk through the ruins.

The description of the destruction is vivid. The enemies hacked the carved work with axes and hatchets. They burned the sanctuary and profaned God’s dwelling place. The worst part is that God’s own place has been dishonored, and his name reviled. The psalmist is grieved less for his own loss than for the offense to God.

Verse 9 is a sorrowful statement: “We do not see our signs; there is no longer any prophet.” The people are in the silence Amos predicted, a famine of hearing the word of the LORD. No prophet knows how long. It is one of the hardest places for faith: when there is no word.

But in verse 12, a turn: “Yet God my King is from of old.” The word “yet” is the pivot. The psalmist recalls what God did: dividing the sea, breaking the heads of the sea monsters, drying up ever-flowing rivers. He remembers the creation: day and night, sun and moon, boundaries of the earth, summer and winter. The God who ordered the cosmos is the same God who is silent now. Memory becomes the foundation for hope.

The psalm ends with a series of petitions. “Have regard for the covenant.” “Arise, O God, defend your cause.” “Remember how the foolish scoff at you all the day.” The psalmist appeals to God’s own honor. He asks God to act for the sake of his own name and covenant. This is the pattern of prayer when everything seems lost: remember who God is, and ask him to act as he has promised.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus predicted the destruction of the temple (Matthew 24:2) and said, “Destroy this temple, and in three days I will raise it up” (John 2:19). He is the true sanctuary that cannot be destroyed. Hebrews 8:1-2 speaks of the true tent. Mark 4:39 shows Jesus rebuking the storm, like God who “divided the sea.” Romans 8:35-39 assures us that nothing can separate us from God’s covenant love.

STEP 6

Application

When things fall apart, follow the psalmist's pattern: state the complaint, then remember what God has done.

Pray for those whose places of worship have been destroyed or who cannot worship freely.

Pray, "Have regard for the covenant," knowing that God has bound himself to you in Christ.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God about what feels like abandonment.
- Remember aloud that he is King from of old.
- Ask him to remember his covenant and his people.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 53

"But I with the voice of thanksgiving will sacrifice to you; what I have vowed I will pay. Salvation belongs to the LORD!"

JONAH 2:9

DAY 369 · WEEK 53

Psalm 77

I cry aloud to God; I remember your deeds

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Psalm · 20 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 77. You read this psalm in Unit 6. This time read it as the prayer of someone who has lived through national catastrophe. Notice how the psalmist moves from his own distress to the memory of the exodus.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 77 is a psalm of Asaph, and it belongs with the other Asaph psalms of this unit. You read it earlier as an example of the discipline of remembering. Now, at the end of the divided kingdom and the fall of Israel, it takes on a new weight. When God's people were cast into exile, this was the question: has his steadfast love ceased? And the answer given is: remember the exodus.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I cry aloud to God, aloud to God, and he will hear me" (v. 1).
2. "In the day of my trouble I seek the Lord; in the night my hand is stretched out without wearying; my soul refuses to be comforted" (v. 2).
3. "I remember God, and I am troubled; I meditate, and my spirit faints" (v. 3).
4. "Will the Lord spurn forever, and never again be favorable? Has his steadfast love forever ceased?" (vv. 7-8).
5. "Has God forgotten to be gracious? Has he in anger shut up his compassion?" (v. 9).
6. "Then I said, This is my grief: that the right hand of the Most High has changed" (v. 10).
7. "I will remember the deeds of the LORD; yes, I will remember your wonders of old" (v. 11).

8 “Your way was through the sea, your path through the great waters; yet your footprints were unseen. You led your people like a flock by the hand of Moses and Aaron” (vv. 19-20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm is a record of a spiritual struggle. The psalmist cries out. He cannot sleep. His soul “refuses to be comforted.” Even remembering God makes him troubled. This is a striking detail: the thought of God, which should comfort, brings distress because God seems absent. He asks a series of questions that every believer in exile has asked: Will the Lord reject forever? Has his steadfast love ceased? Has he forgotten to be gracious?

These are honest questions, and the Bible includes them. Faith does not require us to suppress doubt. It requires us to bring it to God.

The turn comes in verse 10 and 11. The psalmist says, “This is my grief.” Some read the line as: “It is my weakness that the right hand of the Most High has changed.” The meaning is that he has been looking at the problem from the wrong angle. He decides to change his focus. “I will remember the deeds of the LORD; I will remember your wonders of old.” He deliberately turns his mind from his present trouble to God’s past acts.

He then recounts the exodus. God’s way was in the sea, in the great waters, “yet your footprints were unseen.” This is a striking line. God’s footprints were not visible, but he was there. The people crossed the sea, led by an invisible God. In our own times of darkness, we may not see the footprints, but he is leading.

The psalm ends with a quiet image: “You led your people like a flock by the hand of Moses and Aaron.” It is a modest closing line. God leads through ordinary human leaders. The God of the thunder and lightning also leads like a shepherd.

For a people in exile, this was the answer. Remember the exodus. God has rescued before, and he will again.

STEP 5

Connection

The exodus is the pattern of the greater salvation in Christ, who leads us out of slavery to sin (Luke 9:31 speaks of his “exodus” in Jerusalem). Hebrews 13:20 calls him the “great shepherd of the sheep.” Jesus walked on the sea, and his footsteps were seen by the disciples in the storm (Mark 6:48-51). 1 Corinthians 10:1-4 describes the passage through the sea as a baptism into Moses.

STEP 6

Application

When you feel that God has changed, practice remembering. Write a list of his past deeds in your life.

Bring your honest questions to God. Do not edit them.

Look back for “footprints” you did not see at the time.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Cry aloud to God and tell him what your soul refuses to be comforted about.

Remember one of his wonders and rest on it.

Thank him that he leads like a flock, even through unseen footprints.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 53

“But I with the voice of thanksgiving will sacrifice to you; what I have vowed I will pay. Salvation belongs to the LORD!”

JONAH 2:9

DAY 370 · WEEK 53

Jonah 1:1-2:10

Jonah flees; the storm; the great fish

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 27 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jonah 1:1-2:10. A reluctant prophet runs from God's call, a storm threatens the ship, and a great fish swallows Jonah. Read the story as the Bible tells it: with humor, irony, and a surprising ending.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jonah son of Amittai was a prophet in the northern kingdom during Jeroboam II (see 2 Kings 14:25). God sends him to Nineveh, the capital of Assyria, the empire that will later destroy Israel. For an Israelite, this was the last place he would want to go. The book is unusual among the prophets: it is mostly a story about the prophet rather than his sermons. And it shows that God's mercy reaches those whom Israel considered enemies.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Arise, go to Nineveh, that great city, and call out against it, for their evil has come up before me" (1:2).
2. "But Jonah rose to flee to Tarshish from the presence of the LORD" (1:3).
3. "But the LORD hurled a great wind upon the sea" (1:4).
4. "But Jonah had gone down into the inner part of the ship and had lain down and was fast asleep" (1:5).
5. "I am a Hebrew, and I fear the LORD, the God of heaven, who made the sea and the dry land" (1:9).
6. "Pick me up and hurl me into the sea; then the sea will quiet down for you" (1:12).

7. “Then the men feared the LORD exceedingly, and they offered a sacrifice to the LORD and made vows” (1:16).

8. “And the LORD appointed a great fish to swallow up Jonah. And Jonah was in the belly of the fish three days and three nights” (1:17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The book begins with a command and a flight. Jonah is told to go to Nineveh, and he goes in the opposite direction. The text notes the movement: he goes down to Joppa, down into the ship, down into the hold. Every step is downward. When we run from God, we go down.

The irony is rich. The pagan sailors are devout and the prophet is asleep. They cry out to their gods, while the one man who knows the true God is unconscious. The captain says to him, “Arise, call out to your god!” using the same words God had said to Jonah in 1:2. When Jonah confesses, “I fear the LORD, the God of heaven, who made the sea and the dry land,” the irony is complete. He says he fears the LORD, yet he is running from him. His words are right, but his life is not.

The sailors are more compassionate than Jonah. They try to row back to land rather than throw him overboard. They pray that they will not be guilty of innocent blood. And when they do throw him in and the sea grows calm, they fear the LORD and offer a sacrifice. The pagans are converted, and the prophet is sinking.

Then God appoints a great fish. The fish is not a punishment but an act of rescue. Jonah was drowning, and God saves him. Chapter 2 is Jonah’s prayer from inside the fish, and it is a psalm of thanksgiving. He describes sinking into the deep, with seaweed wrapped around his head. “I called out to the LORD, out of my distress, and he answered me.” He recalls that he was cast “into the heart of the seas.” He confesses: “Those who pay regard to vain idols forsake their hope of steadfast love.” And he concludes: “Salvation belongs to the LORD!”

The prayer is theologically right, but notice that it contains no repentance for running away. Jonah thanks God for deliverance but does not yet say that he will obey. The fish then vomits him onto dry land. Salvation is God’s work from beginning to end.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “An evil and adulterous generation seeks for a sign, but no sign will be given to it except the sign of the prophet Jonah. For as Jonah was three days and three nights in the belly of the great fish, so will the Son of Man be three days and three nights in the heart of

the earth" (Matthew 12:39-40). Jesus slept in a boat during a storm and calmed it (Mark 4:38-39). He is the one who was thrown into the sea of judgment so that others might be saved. "Salvation belongs to the LORD" is fulfilled in Jesus, whose name means "The LORD saves."

STEP 6

Application

Where are you running from something God has asked of you? Name it.

Notice the grace of God in the "appointed fish" in your life, rescues you did not recognize at the time.

Pray Jonah's last line, "Salvation belongs to the LORD," as a statement of trust.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you have run from God.
- Thank him for pursuing you and rescuing you.
- Ask him to help you go where he sends.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 53

"But I with the voice of thanksgiving will sacrifice to you; what I have vowed I will pay. Salvation belongs to the LORD!"

JONAH 2:9

DAY 371 · WEEK 53

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Jonah 2:9 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"But I with the voice of thanksgiving will sacrifice to you; what I have vowed I will pay. Salvation belongs to the LORD!"

JONAH 2:9

REST

Meditation

Jonah says these words from inside the great fish. He has just been swallowed, and he is saved. The last line has become one of the central statements of the Bible's teaching on salvation.

"But I with the voice of thanksgiving will sacrifice to you." Jonah contrasts himself with those who worship idols, mentioned in the previous verse. They give their loyalty to what is worthless. He will give thanks to the LORD. The sacrifice he promises is not an animal but the voice of thanksgiving. This echoes Psalm 50:14, which you read earlier: "Offer to God a sacrifice of thanksgiving."

"What I have vowed I will pay." Jonah made vows in his distress. Many of us do the same: we promise God things in a crisis. Jonah says he will keep his word. It is a commitment to obedience, and one that he will be tested on when he is called again to go to Nineveh.

“Salvation belongs to the LORD!” This is the summary of the story and of the Bible. Salvation is not something we produce or earn. It is not found in idols, in human strength, or in our own efforts. It belongs to the LORD. He is the one who saves, from the storm, from the deep, from judgment, and from death.

The sailors were saved by recognizing it. Jonah was saved by his rescue. And Nineveh will be saved because the LORD is the God of salvation, whether the prophet likes it or not.

For the Christian, this is the heart of the gospel. “For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God” (Ephesians 2:8). Say this verse when you are tempted to think that you saved yourself, or that someone is beyond saving.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the psalms of lament and justice: Psalms 74 and 77 on the fall of the sanctuary and the memory of the exodus, and Psalms 58, 82, 94, 109, 140, and 142 on the God who judges and defends the poor. You walked through the whole book of Hosea, from the unfaithful wife and the names of No Mercy and Not My People, through the lawsuit against Israel, to the cry of a heartbroken father, “How can I give you up?”, and the promise of healing in chapter 14. You also read the first half of Jonah: a prophet running away, a storm, pagan sailors who feared the LORD, and a fish appointed by God. The week taught that God’s love pursues the unfaithful, that he desires mercy and not sacrifice, and that salvation belongs to the LORD.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Hosea shows God buying back an unfaithful wife. Where do you most need to remember that you were redeemed rather than earned your place?

Jesus said that the sign of Jonah points to his death and resurrection. How does Jonah’s rescue from the deep help you understand the gospel?

Jonah ran from a call that seemed too hard. Is there something you are running from that God is asking you to do?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Offer God thanksgiving for pursuing you.

Pray, “Salvation belongs to the LORD,” and mean it.

Thank Jesus, who entered the depths for you.

DAY 372 · WEEK 54

Jonah 3:1-4:11

Nineveh repents; Jonah's anger, God's mercy

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 21 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Jonah 3:1-4:11. God commands Jonah a second time, Nineveh repents, and Jonah is angry. The book ends with a question and no answer. Read it slowly and ask what the question is asking of you.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jonah has been rescued and returned to dry land. The word of the LORD comes to him "a second time." This is the last scene of a book that began with a runaway prophet. Nineveh was the capital of Assyria, the cruel empire that would soon destroy the northern kingdom. For Jonah to preach to them and see them spared is a scandal, and the book exposes why.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Now the word of the LORD came to Jonah the second time" (3:1).
2. "Yet forty days, and Nineveh shall be overthrown!" (3:4).
3. "And the people of Nineveh believed God. They called for a fast and put on sackcloth" (3:5).
4. "Who knows? God may turn and relent and turn from his fierce anger, so that we may not perish" (3:9).
5. "When God saw what they did, how they turned from their evil way, God relented of the disaster that he had said he would do to them" (3:10).
6. "But it displeased Jonah exceedingly, and he was angry" (4:1).
7. "For I knew that you are a gracious God and merciful, slow to anger and abounding in steadfast love, and relenting from disaster" (4:2).

8 “And should not I pity Nineveh, that great city, in which there are more than 120,000 persons who do not know their right hand from their left, and also much cattle?” (4:11).

STEP 4

Interpretation

God gives Jonah a second chance. This is a pattern in Scripture: the God who rescues also recommissions. This time Jonah goes, and his sermon is eight words in Hebrew. There is no call to repent in it, only a warning. Yet the whole city believes. From the greatest to the least they fast and wear sackcloth, and even the king takes off his robe and sits in ashes. The most unlikely audience in the Old Testament responds better than Israel ever did to many prophets.

The king’s reasoning is worth noting: “Who knows? God may turn and relent.” He has no guarantee. He repents on the bare chance of mercy. And God does relent. This does not mean God changed his mind in a way that surprised him. It shows that his threats of judgment are real invitations to repent, and that when people turn, he is always ready to forgive.

Chapter 4 is the real point of the book. Jonah is furious. His prayer reveals why he ran in the first place: “I knew that you are a gracious God and merciful, slow to anger and abounding in steadfast love.” He quotes the great self-description of God from Exodus 34:6, and he resents it. He did not want Nineveh to be shown the mercy that he himself had just received. The prophet who was rescued from the deep is angry that God rescues others.

God does not rebuke him harshly. He asks a question: “Do you do well to be angry?” Then he uses a plant, a worm, and a scorching wind to teach him. Jonah pities the plant that gave him shade, though he did not make it. Should God not pity a city of 120,000 people, and even the animals?

The book ends with that question, unanswered. We do not know what Jonah did. The question is left for the reader. Will you rejoice in God’s mercy to those you think do not deserve it?

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said that the men of Nineveh will rise up at the judgment and condemn the generation that rejected him, “for they repented at the preaching of Jonah, and behold, something greater than Jonah is here” (Matthew 12:41). Jesus told the parable of the prodigal son, which also ends with an angry older brother outside the feast (Luke 15:28-32). 1 Timothy 2:3-4 says God desires all people to be saved. Acts 10:34-35 shows Peter learning that God shows no partiality. 2 Peter 3:9 says God is patient, not wishing that any should perish.

STEP 6

Application

Ask yourself who your “Nineveh” is, a person or group you would rather not see forgiven.

Pray for God to show mercy to someone you find hard to love.

Thank God for giving you a second chance, as he gave Jonah.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the second chance he gave you.
- Ask him to search your heart for anger where he is merciful.
- Ask him to teach you to care for those you would rather not.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 54

“He has told you, O man, what is good; and what does the LORD require of you but to do justice, and to love kindness, and to walk humbly with your God?”

MICAH 6:8

DAY 373 · WEEK 54

Micah 1:1-3:12

Judgment on Samaria and Jerusalem

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 50 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Micah 1:1-3:12. Micah was a prophet from a small town in Judah, and he speaks for the poor against the powerful. Read these chapters as a courtroom speech, and notice who is accused.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Micah prophesied in Judah during the reigns of Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah, in the same period as Isaiah and Hosea. He came from Moresheth, a village in the countryside, far from the court. His message is about both Samaria and Jerusalem. Where Hosea spoke of love, and Amos of justice, Micah brings both together and ends with a promise of a ruler from Bethlehem.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Hear, you peoples, all of you; pay attention, O earth, and all that is in it, and let the Lord GOD be a witness against you” (1:2).
2. “Woe to those who devise wickedness and work evil on their beds! When the morning dawns, they perform it, because it is in the power of their hand” (2:1).
3. “They covet fields and seize them, and houses, and take them away; they oppress a man and his house, a man and his inheritance” (2:2).
4. “If a man should go about and utter wind and lies, saying, I will preach to you of wine and strong drink, he would be the preacher for this people!” (2:11).
5. “Is it not for you to know justice?” (3:1).
6. “You who hate the good and love the evil, who tear the skin from off my people” (3:2).

7. “Its heads give judgment for a bribe; its priests teach for a price; its prophets practice divination for money” (3:11).

8. “But as for me, I am filled with power, with the Spirit of the LORD, and with justice and might, to declare to Jacob his transgression and to Israel his sin” (3:8).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Micah begins with a cosmic summons. All the peoples of the earth are called to hear, and the LORD himself comes down from his temple, the mountains melt under his feet. The first judgment falls on Samaria and Judah for idolatry and corruption. The prophet is so grieved that he goes barefoot and naked and wails like a jackal.

The center of chapter 2 is economic sin. People lie awake at night planning how to seize fields and houses. Because they have the power, they do it. This is not a distant, abstract evil. It is landowners taking the inheritance of poorer families, each one of whom held land as a gift of the covenant. To take the land is to attack God’s gift. And Micah notes that the people prefer false prophets: if a man preaches comfort, wine, and strong drink, he is their kind of preacher.

Chapter 3 turns on the leaders. Rulers who should know justice hate the good. Micah uses a shocking image: they eat the flesh of the people and flay their skin. When they cry to the LORD, he will not answer. Prophets who mislead the people for money will find that the vision becomes night. Then Micah gives his own claim: “I am filled with power, with the Spirit of the LORD.” His message is not his own invention. It has the authority of God’s Spirit.

The chapter ends with a verdict: “Therefore because of you Zion shall be plowed as a field, Jerusalem shall become a heap of ruins.” Jeremiah 26:18 later recalls that this prophecy saved Jerusalem in Hezekiah’s day, because the king listened and repented. Hard words can lead to healing when they are heard.

Yet in the middle of chapter 2, there is a flicker of hope: “I will surely assemble all of you, O Jacob… I will set them together like sheep in a fold.” The LORD will be the king who breaks open the way and leads his people out. Judgment is not the last word.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus announced the good news to the poor (Luke 4:18) and warned against those who devour widows’ houses (Mark 12:40). James 5:1-6 warns the rich who defraud workers. Acts 1:8 promises power from the Holy Spirit to witness, as Micah was filled with the Spirit to declare. 1 Peter 5:2-3 charges elders to shepherd the flock willingly, not for shameful gain.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether any of your gain comes at someone else's expense. Look closely at your work and spending.

Pray for leaders in the church to teach faithfully and not for a price.

Pray for the courage to speak truth, as Micah did, in the power of the Spirit.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to keep you from coveting and seizing what is not yours.

Pray for church leaders to be faithful and free from greed.

Ask him to fill you with power, justice, and might by his Spirit.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 54

"He has told you, O man, what is good; and what does the LORD require of you but to do justice, and to love kindness, and to walk humbly with your God?"

MICAH 6:8

DAY 374 · WEEK 54

Micah 4:1-5:15

Bethlehem's ruler; future peace among the nations

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 28 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Micah 4:1-5:15. After the judgments of chapters 1 to 3, the tone changes to hope. Read the vision of the mountain of the LORD, then slow down at 5:2, the promise of a ruler from Bethlehem.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

These two chapters are the hinge of Micah. After the threat of destruction, God shows what he will do beyond it: gather the nations to Zion, bring peace, and raise up a ruler who will shepherd his people. Verse 5:2 is one of the best known prophecies of the coming Messiah, and it was already being quoted by the scribes in Jesus' day.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "It shall come to pass in the latter days that the mountain of the house of the LORD shall be established as the highest of the mountains" (4:1).
2. "Many nations shall come, and say: Come, let us go up to the mountain of the LORD" (4:2).
3. "They shall beat their swords into plowshares, and their spears into pruning hooks; nation shall not lift up sword against nation" (4:3).
4. "But they shall sit every man under his vine and under his fig tree, and no one shall make them afraid" (4:4).
5. "And you, O Bethlehem Ephrathah, who are too little to be among the clans of Judah, from you shall come forth for me one who is to be ruler in Israel" (5:2).
6. "Whose coming forth is from of old, from ancient days" (5:2).

7. “And he shall stand and shepherd his flock in the strength of the LORD” (5:4).

8. “And he shall be their peace” (5:5).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Micah 4:1-3 is almost identical to Isaiah 2:2-4, a sign of how important this vision was to the prophets. In the last days, the temple mount will be exalted, and the nations will come, not as conquered subjects but as willing learners. “He may teach us his ways and that we may walk in his paths.” The word of the LORD will go out from Jerusalem. And as a result, the nations will stop fighting. Weapons become farming tools. Everyone sits under their own vine and fig tree, a picture of security and peace.

What makes this vision striking is its setting. It follows the destruction of chapter 3. The very hill that will be plowed like a field becomes the highest mountain. God does not give up on his plan. Out of ruins he builds a worldwide kingdom.

The prophet admits that suffering comes first. Israel will go to Babylon, “writhing like a woman in labor,” but there God will rescue and redeem them. Their enemies think they are finished, but “they do not know the thoughts of the LORD.”

Then comes 5:2. Bethlehem was a tiny village, “too little to be among the clans of Judah.” Yet from it will come the ruler of Israel. God consistently chooses the small things. David had been the youngest son from this same town. And the ruler’s origin is “from of old, from ancient days,” language that points beyond a merely human king. He will “shepherd his flock in the strength of the LORD,” and “they shall dwell secure, for now he shall be great to the ends of the earth.” And the key line: “And he shall be their peace.”

He does not just bring peace. He is peace. The final part of the chapter promises the purging of idols and the removal of every false security. The kingdom is not built on horses and chariots but on the LORD.

STEP 5

Connection

When the magi came to Jerusalem asking where the king of the Jews was born, the chief priests and scribes quoted Micah 5:2 (Matthew 2:1-6). Jesus is the shepherd (John 10:11) and “our peace” (Ephesians 2:14). The nations streaming to the mountain of the LORD are fulfilled in the gathering of the church from every tribe (Revelation 7:9). Isaiah 9:6-7 names the coming child “Prince of Peace.”

STEP 6

Application

Reread Micah 5:2 and thank God for Bethlehem, a small place that held the greatest gift.

Notice where God works through things that seem small and overlooked, including in your own life.

Pray for peace in a specific conflict, and for the day when swords become plowshares.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the ruler from little Bethlehem.
- Ask him to shepherd you in his strength.
- Ask him to be your peace.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 54

"He has told you, O man, what is good; and what does the LORD require of you but to do justice, and to love kindness, and to walk humbly with your God?"

MICAH 6:8

DAY 375 · WEEK 54

Micah 6:1-7:20

"Do justice, love mercy"; God pardons iniquity

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 36 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Micah 6:1-7:20. God brings a lawsuit against his people, and Micah answers with the most famous summary of the faith in the prophets. Read 6:8 carefully, then enjoy the ending, which is among the loveliest statements of forgiveness in the Bible.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This final section of Micah is built as a courtroom scene, followed by a lament and a hymn of confidence. God calls the mountains and hills to be the jury, and he asks Israel what he has done to deserve her unfaithfulness. The prophet's answer to the question of what God requires has become a guide for Christians and Jews alike. The book ends not with judgment but with a song about a God who pardons.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "O my people, what have I done to you? How have I wearied you? Answer me!" (6:3).
2. "I brought you up from the land of Egypt and redeemed you from the house of slavery" (6:4).
3. "With what shall I come before the LORD, and bow myself before God on high? Shall I come before him with burnt offerings?" (6:6).
4. "Shall I give my firstborn for my transgression, the fruit of my body for the sin of my soul?" (6:7).
5. "He has told you, O man, what is good; and what does the LORD require of you but to do justice, and to love kindness, and to walk humbly with your God?" (6:8).
6. "Woe is me! For I have become as when the summer fruit has been gathered" (7:1).

7. “But as for me, I will look to the LORD; I will wait for the God of my salvation; my God will hear me” (7:7).

8. “Who is a God like you, pardoning iniquity and passing over transgression for the remnant of his inheritance? He does not retain his anger forever, because he delights in steadfast love” (7:18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The lawsuit opens with God’s tender question: “O my people, what have I done to you?” He does not accuse first. He asks. He reminds them of the exodus, of Moses, Aaron, and Miriam, and of the story of Balaam. Everything he has done has been for their good. “Remember… that you may know the righteous acts of the LORD.”

The people respond with a panic of religious inflation. What does God want? Burnt offerings? Calves a year old? Thousands of rams, ten thousand rivers of oil? Even their firstborn? The questions escalate toward absurdity. They think that if enough is given, God will be satisfied. This is the religion of bargaining, and it is the opposite of the gospel.

The answer in 6:8 is simple and searching. “He has told you what is good.” It is not a secret. The LORD requires three things. To do justice: to act rightly toward others, especially the weak. To love kindness: the word is the covenant love hesed, loyal, merciful love that we should delight in, not merely practice. And to walk humbly with your God: a life lived in daily company with him, aware of dependence. This is Hosea 6:6 in another form. It is the same heart of the faith.

Chapter 7 begins with grief. Micah feels as if he is alone in a world with no godly person left. Even families are divided. But then comes a great “but as for me.” “I will look to the LORD; I will wait for the God of my salvation.” When the enemy mocks, he says, “Rejoice not over me, O my enemy; when I fall, I shall rise.” He accepts the LORD’s discipline because he knows that the LORD will plead his cause.

The book ends with a hymn: “Who is a God like you?” It lists what God does with sin: he pardons iniquity, passes over transgression, does not retain his anger, has compassion, tramples our iniquities underfoot, and casts all our sins into the depths of the sea. He keeps the promise he swore to Abraham and Jacob.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said the weightier matters of the law are justice, mercy, and faithfulness (Matthew 23:23). Hebrews 10:5-10 says that the sacrifices could never take away sins, but the offering of Christ's body does. In Christ the sins are cast into the sea (Colossians 2:13-14; Hebrews 8:12). Ephesians 2:8-10 says we are saved by grace, created for good works. Romans 12:1 calls us to present our bodies as a living sacrifice.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Micah 6:8 and take one concrete action today in each of its three parts.

Consider where you are tempted to bargain with God, as the people did.

Thank God that your sins are cast into the depths of the sea. Say it aloud.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what it looks like for you to do justice, love kindness, and walk humbly this week.

Thank him that he pardons iniquity.

Ask him to teach you to do this out of love and not to earn his love.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 54

"He has told you, O man, what is good; and what does the LORD require of you but to do justice, and to love kindness, and to walk humbly with your God?"

MICAH 6:8

DAY 376 · WEEK 54

2 Kings 16:1-17:41

Ahaz; the fall of Samaria, the northern kingdom exiled

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Reading · 65 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read 2 Kings 16:1-17:41. These chapters give the fall of the northern kingdom. Notice the contrast between Ahaz of Judah and the kings of Israel, and read the long explanation in chapter 17 of why Israel fell.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The prophets you have read in this unit, Amos, Hosea, Jonah, and Micah, spoke before this event. Now the narrator tells what happened. In 722 BC, Assyria captured Samaria and took Israel into exile, ending the northern kingdom that Jeroboam had founded two centuries earlier. The southern kingdom of Judah, under Ahaz, was saved for a time, but it followed the same path.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “But he walked in the way of the kings of Israel. He even burned his son as an offering” (16:3).
2. “And King Ahaz went to Damascus to meet Tiglath-pileser king of Assyria… and saw the altar that was at Damascus” (16:10).
3. “In the ninth year of Hoshea, the king of Assyria captured Samaria, and he carried the Israelites away to Assyria” (17:6).
4. “And this occurred because the people of Israel had sinned against the LORD their God, who had brought them up out of the land of Egypt” (17:7).
5. “Yet the LORD warned Israel and Judah by every prophet and every seer, saying, Turn from your evil ways” (17:13).

6. “But they would not listen, but were stubborn, as their fathers had been, who did not believe in the LORD their God” (17:14).
7. “They went after false idols and became false” (17:15).
8. “They feared the LORD but also served their own gods” (17:33).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 16 describes Ahaz of Judah, one of the worst kings. He burned his own son as an offering, sacrificed at the high places, and when threatened by Syria and Israel, sent the temple treasures to the king of Assyria for help rather than trusting the LORD. Isaiah had told him to trust God (Isaiah 7), but he would not. He then copied a pagan altar he saw in Damascus and had it installed in the temple, pushing the bronze altar aside. A king who should have led the people to God remodeled God’s house to fit the world.

Chapter 17 is the theological summary of the whole northern kingdom. The fall of Samaria is told in just a few verses. The rest is an explanation. Israel fell because they had sinned against the LORD who had brought them out of Egypt. The list is long: they feared other gods, followed the customs of the nations, built high places, set up pillars and Asherim, burned incense, served idols, and sacrificed their sons and daughters. “They despised his statutes and his covenant.”

One line stands out. “They went after false idols and became false.” We become like what we worship. Those who worship empty things become empty. And the writer insists that God had warned them: “by every prophet and every seer.” The judgment was not unjust or sudden. It followed centuries of patient calls to return. Hosea, Amos, and others had given fair warning.

The chapter ends with a tragic picture. The Assyrians resettled foreigners in the land, who feared the LORD in a superficial way while still serving their own gods. “They feared the LORD but also served their own gods.” It is a portrait of syncretism, trying to mix the true God with others. The verse repeats: “To this day they do according to their former manner.”

The warning for the reader is plain. Hearing the word is not enough. The covenant requires faithful obedience from the heart. Judah is next, and the same pattern will bring them to Babylon.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus said, “You cannot serve God and money” (Matthew 6:24). Paul writes that the things which happened to Israel “were written down for our instruction” (1 Corinthians 10:11). 1 John 5:21 ends: “Little children, keep yourselves from idols.” Romans 11:20-22 warns the church not to be proud but to continue in God’s kindness. Samaria later became the place of the encounter of Jesus with a Samaritan woman (John 4) and the gospel’s early spread (Acts 8).

STEP 6

Application

Ask what you fear and serve alongside God. Be honest, and name it.

Remember that you become like what you worship. Ask what you are becoming like.

Thank God for the prophets who warned and for the greater prophet who came.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to help you listen to what he has already said.
- Ask him to keep you from mixing worship with the idols of your age.
- Name one idol and give it to him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 54

“He has told you, O man, what is good; and what does the LORD require of you but to do justice, and to love kindness, and to walk humbly with your God?”

MICAH 6:8

DAY 377 · WEEK 54

Review and Reflection

Unit 11 review, The Divided Kingdom & Early Prophets

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "For I desire steadfast love and not sacrifice, the knowledge of God rather than burnt offerings."
>
> HOSEA 6:6

REST

Meditation

This is the anchor verse of the unit, and Jesus quoted it twice. It summarizes what the prophets of the divided kingdom said again and again. Israel had built a religion of rituals and sacrifices while its heart was far from God, and its society was full of injustice.

"I desire steadfast love and not sacrifice." God does not reject sacrifice, for he commanded it. But he refuses sacrifice without love. Ritual that is cut off from covenant loyalty is empty. The heart that gives to God what he wants will also care for the poor, be faithful to the covenant, and refuse idols.

"The knowledge of God rather than burnt offerings." To know God is to be in relationship with him: to trust, to love, and to obey. It is the thing Hosea said was missing in the land. When people know God, they act with justice and mercy. Micah says the same in 6:8, and Amos in 5:24.

Say the verse from memory. Then ask what it would mean for your own devotion. Is there any activity of faith that you do, but without love? What would it look like to know God more deeply this week?

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

This unit followed the divided kingdom from its beginning to its end. After Solomon's death, the nation split. Jeroboam set up golden calves at Dan and Bethel, and "the sin of Jeroboam" became the standard by which each northern king was judged. Prophets arose to call the

people back. Elijah confronted Ahab and Jezebel on Mount Carmel, and Elisha carried on his work with miracles of mercy. Amos preached justice, that it should "roll down like waters." Hosea married an unfaithful wife and showed God's heartbroken, faithful love. Jonah was sent to Assyria and learned that God's mercy reaches even enemies. Micah spoke for the poor and promised a ruler from Bethlehem. Finally, in 722 BC, Samaria fell. The psalms of the unit gave voice to lament, to cries for justice, and to hope. Through it all, God's steadfast love does not give up, and the greater prophet is on the way.

REFLECT

Review Questions

What was the sin of Jeroboam, and why did it become the measure for every northern king after him?

Think about 1 Kings 12:25-33 and what it shows about the danger of making worship convenient and political.

How do Elijah and Elisha point forward to John the Baptist and to Jesus?

Consider the confrontation on Mount Carmel, the still small voice, the raising of the dead, and the feeding of many from little.

What did Hosea's marriage to Gomer teach about the heart of God toward his people?

Consider the names of the children, the purchase of Gomer in chapter 3, and the cry of "How can I give you up?"

What does the book of Jonah teach about the scope of God's mercy, and what does it ask of the reader?

Think about Nineveh's repentance, Jonah's anger, and the unanswered question at the end.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the prophets who warned and for the grace that follows.

Tell him how you want to know him more than offer religious activity.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.

DAY 378 · WEEK 54

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 11 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Micah 6:8 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"He has told you, O man, what is good; and what does the LORD require of you but to do justice, and to love kindness, and to walk humbly with your God?"

MICAH 6:8

REST

Meditation

This verse has been called the whole of religion in a sentence. It follows a series of absurd questions: how many sacrifices would be enough? Micah cuts through them. "He has told you." God's will is not hidden. It is not a puzzle for experts. It has been spoken clearly, and it is simple, though not easy.

"To do justice." Justice is not an idea to hold but a thing to do. It means setting right what is wrong, especially for those who have no power to defend themselves. It is the opposite of the land-grabbing and bribe-taking that Micah condemned.

"To love kindness." The word is hesed, covenant loyalty and mercy. We are not only to practice kindness but to love it, to delight in being merciful, as God delights in showing mercy. It is the difference between a duty performed and a joy shared.

“To walk humbly with your God.” The image is of a companion on a journey. We walk with God, not ahead of him or away from him. Humility means we know we are dependent on his grace, that we did not earn our place beside him.

This verse does not replace the gospel. It describes the life of those who have received it. We cannot do any of these three things by our own power. Jesus did them perfectly in our place, and through his Spirit he now enables us to follow him. Say this verse as a prayer for the week ahead.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished the book of Jonah and learned that God’s mercy extends even to Nineveh, and that the prophet who was rescued from the deep was angry at the mercy shown to others. You read Micah, the prophet from a small village, who spoke against land-grabbing, corrupt leaders, and false prophets, and who promised a ruler from tiny Bethlehem who would be the peace of his people. You read the lawsuit of chapter 6 and its great summary of what God requires, and the closing hymn to the God who casts our sins into the depths of the sea. And you read the account of the fall of Samaria in 2 Kings, with its sober explanation: they would not listen. The week taught that God asks for justice, kindness, and humble faith, and that he delights to pardon.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Jonah was angry that God showed mercy to Nineveh. Is there anyone whose forgiveness you find hard to accept?

Micah promises that a ruler will come from little Bethlehem, and that “he shall be their peace.” How has Christ been your peace?

Micah 6:8 names three things: do justice, love kindness, walk humbly. Which one do you most need to grow in this week, and what is one step you can take?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what doing justice, loving kindness, and walking humbly will look like for you.

Thank Jesus, who is our peace and casts sins into the depths of the sea.

Rest in him today.